Race in Local Government Meetings

by

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ABSTRACT

Does a city council's racial composition affect what is discussed in council meetings? Studies of local politics infer these effects from policy outcomes, but a council settles what counts as a problem in public meetings before it decides anything. To measure what councils discuss, I classify transcripts from over 8,000 meetings with a large language model, recording whether race is engaged, whether race is engaged symbolically or substantively, and which of six policy areas it concerns. Race is a small and concentrated share of local deliberation, with a minority of cities accounting for most of it and a number of cities recording none at all. When race is engaged it is more often substantive than symbolic, meaning it is tied to policy rather than to the commemoration of a group. Symbolic language concentrates outside the policy areas, in proclamations and ceremonial business. Race-language rises with the non-white share of a council, but the association is weak. Council composition and city population composition are too closely related across these cities to be told apart. Neither a regression discontinuity design nor a two-way fixed effects design produces an estimate that can be distinguished from zero, and the smallest effect either could reliably detect is larger than the quantity it would move. What is ruled out is an effect far larger than the movement cities record from one year to the next. This paper supplies an empirical foundation for future work, a measure of what councils attend to and the scale any effect must reach to be found.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Who sits in a legislature communicates something about who the legislature is for, independently of how that legislature votes. Mansbridge (1999) argues that descriptive representation carries social meaning and confers legitimacy on that basis, and that the case for it is strongest where a group has faced historical subordination and doubts about its ability to rule. Descriptive representation also changes how citizens relate to their government. It helps reduce gaps in political participation (Bobo and Gilliam 1990; Barreto 2007; Fraga 2018). It also affects trust in government, including trust in local government specifically (Hero and Tolbert 2004; Heideman 2020). There is every reason to expect those benefits to be largest in local government, where race is the dominant cleavage in urban vote choice, where electoral rules decide whether minority candidates win at all, and where racial circumstances affect how local goods are distributed (Z. Hajnal and Trounstine 2014; Abott and Magazinnik 2020; Trounstine 2016; Trounstine 2020). A council whose racial composition changes is a council whose relationship to its residents changes, and the literature on race in local politics suggests that these descriptive differences should translate into differences in governance as well.

Two arguments, however, hold that a council's racial composition does not change how a city is governed. The first is that what matters is the composition of the constituency rather

than the composition of the council. Swain (1993) suggests that once a city's characteristics are accounted for, the race of a representative does little additional work. Representatives of any race are motivated to serve the constituency that elected them, so what appears to be an effect of an official's race is an effect of the constituency that chose the official. The second is that cities are constrained in what they can do at all. Local governments are focused on services, and they compete with each other for land, labor, and capital, so they are economically constrained (Peterson 1981). With an economic-constraint perspective of local politics, the racial composition of a city council would have a weak effect. The two accounts predict the same null for different reasons. Swain's is a claim about confounding, since the characteristics of a place shape both who holds office and what a government does, and a council usually resembles the population that elected it. Peterson's is a claim about the outcome, since competition for land, labor, and capital limits what any council can deliver regardless of who sits on it. A design that separates a council from its constituency answers the first and leaves the second untouched. The first argument has been contested directly, since minority officials invest in group interests in arenas where the constituency supplies no electoral incentive to do so (Minta 2009; Broockman 2013). Whether descriptive representation leads to substantive representation is therefore questionable, and both sides of the debate give strong arguments. The disagreement is durable, and it is not settled by another study of what a legislature enacts.

The disagreement on the relationship between descriptive and substantive representation is built from examining what a city produces rather than from what a city discusses. Budgets, votes, institutional rules, and policy outcomes all describe a decision after it has been reached, and treat the public meeting as the place where a decision made elsewhere is recorded. Before a city spends money, it has to decide what to spend it on, and before it decides that, someone has to raise the question. A constraint that operates on money does not reach that step on its own, because a council that cannot fund a program can still identify a problem, hear from the residents it affects, and direct staff to study it. What a council attends to is part of

the process of representation, not a step before it, because the concerns a city takes up are the ones its members recognize as concerns, and recognizing a concern sooner is what shared experience is supposed to change (Mansbridge 1999). The meeting is where an effect of racial composition should appear first, and it is where recognition of a concern is observable rather than inferred from what a city later funds.

Studying representation at that step means measuring what a council discusses, and studying racial representation means measuring whether a council engages race at all. First, I establish that racial groups differ in what they want from local government, using a nationally representative survey I co-fielded through YouGov. To examine discussion, I use the LocalView database, which is a collection of transcripts of local government meetings from across the country. I also utilize the American Local Government Elections Database which contains data on the racial composition of city councils. I cut each transcript into topically coherent segments and send each segment to a large language model, which returns three judgments: whether race is engaged, whether race is engaged in symbolic or substantive terms, and which policy areas the segment concerns. Applied across over 8,000 meetings in mid-sized and large cities, this produces a record of what a council spent its meetings on.

After classifying every segment in those meetings, I find that race is a recurring but concentrated feature of local deliberation. Explicit engagement with race is a small share of all classified content, and it is unevenly spread, with a minority of cities accounting for most of it and a number of cities recording none at all. Additionally, when race is engaged it is more often substantive than symbolic, meaning it is attached to something a council could decide rather than to recognition of a group. Symbolic language concentrates outside of policy areas, in proclamations, commemorations, and ceremonial business. I also find that the distinction between symbolic and substantive describes race-language attached to a policy area far better than it describes the rest, since a large share of race-engaging content outside those areas is classified as neither.

These findings cannot be attributed to the council itself. Race-language rises with the

non-white share of a council, but the association is weak. Symbolic and substantive language do not covary at all with composition. Council composition and city population composition are too closely related across these cities to be told apart, which is Swain's problem in a local setting. I use two separate causal designs to separate them, a two-way fixed effects design and a regression discontinuity. Neither design produces an estimate that can be distinguished from zero, and the smallest effect either could reliably detect is larger than the quantity it would move. What is ruled out is an effect far larger than the movement cities record from one year to the next.

What this paper contributes is a way of observing the part of local politics where an effect of composition would have to appear first. This paper measures preferences over the functions cities actually perform, which are usually inferred from national policy questions rather than asked about directly (Anzia 2021). Asking directly shows that white and non-white respondents differ in what they want a city to prioritize, which establishes the premise the rest of the paper rests on rather than assuming it. Knowing that those priorities differ does not establish that a council acts on them, and the meeting is where that would become observable. Work on local meetings has established who gets into the room and how the preferences of those who show up relate to what governments approve (Einstein, Palmer, and Glick 2019; Sahn 2025). What is said once a topic is taken up has not been measured, and measuring it means reading meeting content at a scale that rules out reading it by hand. A large language model applied at topic-level segments does that, and applying it to racialized speech is what turns a corpus of transcripts into a record of how councils engage race. The causal designs contribute a foundation rather than an estimate. Neither produces an estimate distinguishable from zero, but both are built on an outcome measured directly rather than inferred from what a city later funds, which is what allows the smallest effect each design could have detected to be compared against how much cities actually move from one year to the next. That comparison is a useful result because it establishes how large an effect would have to be before a design of this kind could see it, and therefore how much

data a future study would need, which is a specification for the next attempt rather than an answer to the question.

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. The next three sections review what representation and deliberation require of a legislature and what local government does differently. The section that follows develops the three components of meeting content this paper measures and states the hypotheses attached to them. I then report a survey of preferences over local policy, which establishes that racial groups differ in what they want a city to prioritize. The data and measurement sections describe the transcripts, the election records, and the procedure that turns meeting text into segment-level classifications. The results section reports how race is used across the corpus and how it relates to council composition. Two causal designs follow, a two-way fixed effects design and a regression discontinuity design, and a section on power reports what each could have detected. The discussion and conclusion consider what the measure makes possible.

Chapter 2

Background

2.1 Representation

Representation is a relationship where one actor acts for others, and most disagreements about representation are disagreements about which part of that relationship is doing the work. Pitkin (1967) separates representation into three parts: descriptive, symbolic, and substantive. Descriptive representation is when officials share politically salient characteristics with their constituents, such as race and gender. Symbolic representation is based on what an official signifies to constituents and depends on the belief and attachment of the represented rather than any characteristic the official shares or any action the official takes. Substantive representation looks at whether a representative acts in the interest of the represented, or mirrors policy preferences. Another view of representation asks how a government is responsive along four dimensions: policy (achieving desired outcomes), service (securing benefits for constituents), allocation (capacity to deliver funding), and symbolic (ability to create bonds of trust and support) (Eulau and Karps 1977). Given these accounts, representation is not a single quantity that a study can detect or not, and two studies of the same official can reach different conclusions without contradicting one another if one measures enacted policy and the other measures benefits, attention, or trust.

Local governments illustrate how all the pieces of representation can come apart. A city council can mirror the racial composition of its population precisely and never pass a policy that any group in the population cares about. A council that resembles no one can still deliver services and funding that a group would have chosen for itself. A council can be a source of recognition for residents whose material conditions it does nothing to change. Nothing in the concept guarantees that composition travels into action, which is what makes the relationship between descriptive and substantive representation an empirical question rather than a question of definitions. However, separable is not the same as independent, and it is important to consider whether the pieces move together in practice.

Swain (1993) provides reasons why substantive and descriptive representation do not necessarily move together. Swain's argument is not that race is irrelevant to behavior but that its effects are confounded with the constituencies that produce Black officeholders in the first place. Across districts that vary in racial composition, she finds representatives balancing incompatible constituencies, assembling multiracial coalitions, and tuning their public appearance to what their districts will approve of. That behavior is a response to their electoral position and a desire to be reelected, and once one accounts for a district's racial composition, partisanship, and ideology, the race of a representative does little work. Swain ultimately concludes that whites can represent Blacks and Blacks can represent whites and that more descriptive representation does not necessarily lead to greater representation of the tangible interests of Black citizens. Swain's null is well founded, and claiming that substantive and descriptive representation move together has to survive her argument.

There are several critiques of Swain's conclusions. Swain's account of representation is aggregative: interests originate in the district, and the representative's task is to weigh them and act accordingly. Descriptive representation should be expected to matter least under exactly that description. Where politics is aggregative, a vote can be cast on a group's behalf by anyone whose incentives are aligned, and electoral accountability substitutes tolerably well for shared experience. Where politics is deliberative, a perspective has to be carried

into the room by someone who holds it, and no incentive structure fully substitutes for that (Mansbridge 1999). An account built on the first description will find little for descriptive representation to do, not because the evidence rules it out but because the conception leaves it no work. The mechanism Swain proposes also generates an implication that can be checked. If behavior is influenced by electoral incentives, it should diminish where the incentive is absent. However, there is evidence that it does not. Black and Latino members of Congress participate more than white members in oversight hearings on racial issues, an arena that is costly in time and thinner in electoral reward than floor voting (Minta 2009), and Black legislators assist Black constituents who live outside their districts and cannot vote for them (Broockman 2013). Where the district cannot supply the motive, a difference appears anyway.

A large difficulty with Swain's argument concerns the premise that interests are properties of the district. What a district communicates to its officials is not fixed independently of whoever is in office. Constituents are less likely to contact representatives who are not of their race, and two officials representing demographically identical districts therefore hear systematically different things (Broockman 2014). Attributing behavior to the district merely relocates race rather than removing it. Furthermore, descriptive representation does its most distinctive work where interests have not yet crystallized, because a concern that has not been formulated as a demand cannot be detected through tests of preference congruence (Mansbridge 1999). Shared experience matters there not because it changes how a representative votes on a question, but because it changes which questions are asked (Reingold, Widner, and Harmon 2020). The more precise conclusion is therefore that Swain and her critics are not answering the same question. Swain asks whether descriptive representation changes what a legislature produces, while other work finds effects on whether it changes what a legislature attends to and which interests are articulated.

Framing descriptive representation through a debate also undersells the value of the concept. Its effects on the public are well established and occur independently of official

behavior. Descriptive representation helps reduce gaps in political participation (Bobo and Gilliam 1990; Barreto 2007; Fraga 2018). Descriptive representation also affects trust in government, including trust in local government specifically (Hero and Tolbert 2004; Heideman 2020). These are instances of symbolic responsiveness, but they are not permanently symbolic because empowerment, efficacy, and trust ultimately shape who participates in government, showing that symbolic consequences can feed into substantive outcomes further down the line.

What emerges is a set of horizontal relationships rather than a hierarchy. Descriptive representation is not substantive representation and does not reliably produce it. At the same time, descriptive representation can influence what a legislative body attends to and what the public believes about it rather than what it ultimately enacts. This claim applies to deliberative democracy as much as it applies to representation, and it requires saying what deliberation is and which parts of it a study of meetings can observe.

2.2 Deliberation

Deliberation is the process by which a collective body settles what concerns are public problems, works those problems through discussion, and converts discussion into binding decisions that hold for some time. Each stage can be held to a more or less stringent standard, and most disagreements about deliberation are disagreements about which stage carries the democratic weight. For example, some accounts focus on the middle stage and define deliberation as a process in which citizens and representatives justify their decisions by offering one another reasons that both sides can accept and that any citizen can follow, reaching conclusions that bind for now but remain open to later challenge (Gutmann and Thompson 2004). What makes a decision democratic on this account is not that a majority assembled behind it but that those bound by it were owed reasons they could accept.

As defined, deliberation is valuable for three reasons. First, a choice defended with

reasons carries more authority than a choice that has merely been voted upon (Gutmann and Thompson 2004). Second, deliberation leads to higher-quality decisions because a public that reflects collectively on a question will reach different conclusions than one forced to decide immediately (Fishkin 1997). Third, participation is educative before it is anything else. Taking part in deliberation builds the capacity for future participation, and a public accustomed to deliberation is more likely to produce higher-quality decisions (Pateman 1975).

Deliberation matters for this project because it is where representation happens between elections. Elections determine who sits on a council. They do not determine whose concerns are raised, whose account of a problem is regarded as credible, or which questions the body considers before voting. Those are deliberative outcomes, and they are produced continuously rather than every few years. This reasoning motivates treating local representation as a function of discourse between officials and the public rather than merely of electoral outcomes, a view that also holds that national theories travel poorly to cities because local issues are more specific, contact between officials and the public is more difficult in dense places, and local elections are rarely competitive enough to discipline officials on their own (Collins 2018). If representation is worked out through discussion, then what a council discusses is evidence of representation rather than merely a preliminary stage.

The link also runs in the opposite direction because who sits in the room shapes discussion. Composition changes what a body talks about, and as the share of a group increases, discussion shifts toward concerns associated with that group, and this effect can also depend upon institutional rules (Mendelberg, Karpowitz, and Goedert 2014). Composition also changes who is heard, affecting both how much members of a group speak and whether other participants regard them as influential (Karpowitz, Mendelberg, and Shaker 2012). Finally, composition changes how a group's interests are expressed. Where a meeting is racially homogeneous, arguments advancing one group's interest can be made in universal language that sounds reasonable to everyone present, but sounds racist to a racially mixed audience (Mendelberg and Oleske 2000). Together, these findings provide reasons both to

expect the racial composition of councils to shape meeting content and to examine how race is discussed rather than merely whether it is mentioned.

Deliberation understood in this way has multiple components, and this project observes only some of them. It measures what councils attend to and, once race is raised, whether the issue is engaged symbolically or substantively. It cannot observe who is speaking because the transcripts contain no speaker attribution, whether participants respond to one another's arguments or revise their positions in light of them, or whether discussion changes policy outcomes. The reason-giving exchange that lies at the center of normative accounts therefore remains outside the scope of observation. This limitation is important because these omitted components are precisely those through which composition has been shown to matter. Nevertheless, what remains visible is still a genuine component of deliberation, and whether it behaves as the literature predicts depends upon the institutional context in which city councils operate.

2.3 Race and Representation in Local Government

Local government provides a much different context from national politics, and it all starts with acknowledging what it exists to do. Local governments deliver services such as water, sewers, trash collection, and police and fire protection, and they regulate land use and pursue local economic development (Oliver, Ha, and Callen 2012). Few of these functions appear in the debates that divide national politics. Most local elections are also formally nonpartisan, so the label that organizes voting in national contests is not seen on ballots (Wood 2002). City councils are small, which means a single member constitutes a large share of the body and a single seat can meaningfully change a council's composition. The news coverage that would report on any of this has thinned as stations shift attention toward national politics (Martin and McCrain 2019). Furthermore, it is unsettled whether all the unique institutions of local governments create an ideological setting that mirrors national/state

politics. Ideology predicts vote choice in nonpartisan mayoral races, and local policy moves with the ideological composition of the population (Sances 2018; Warshaw 2019). Despite this, the evidence on the influence of ideology in local politics is based on aggregations of public opinion on national policies, and preferences over the functions that local governments actually deliver don't necessarily line up with national ideology (Anzia 2021). Local attitudes do have structure, and some of its structure does line up with national ideology, but there are many local issues that are distinctively local and highly conditional on different contexts (Schaffner, Rhodes, and La Raja 2026).

The strongest reason to expect little from any city council is that cities may not be free to differ. Accounts of what governs local policy sort into four families: economic imperatives, public preferences, responses to local needs, and institutional structures with economic imperatives surviving as a major determinant of what cities focus their budgets on (Z. L. Hajnal and Trounstine 2010). Peterson (1981) argues that cities compete with one another for labor, land, and capital, and that their economic and development strategies are built around that competition. A city cannot focus too heavily on redistribution, because redistributive taxation makes it less attractive to the taxpayers and businesses it depends on. Development pays for itself and redistribution does not, and this holds no matter who holds office. Local politics on this account is not a smaller version of national politics. It has less room for group conflict, and correspondingly less riding on who wins elections. Peterson adds that local elections are typically low-turnout and short on issues, so the electoral pressure that might force a council off the growth path is weak to begin with. The implication for a study of racial composition is direct. If group-targeted policy is foreclosed by a city's economic position, the racial makeup of a council should not have much of an effect.

Cities nonetheless vary from one another in ways that the economic-constraint perspective doesn't anticipate. City policy moves with the preferences of city residents, with liberal cities spending more than conservative ones (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014; Einstein and Kogan 2016). Partisanship shapes policy even when the elections don't have party labels, with

the partisanship of mayors having an effect on multifamily housing permitting (Benedictis-Kessner, D. Jones, and Warshaw 2025). Outside of parties, interest groups also organize around local questions and pressure local governments (Anzia 2022). Together this evidence establishes that cities differ in what they spend and on whom, which is difficult to reconcile with a strong reading of the constraint. It does not establish that the constraint is weak where money is actually at stake, and it remains concentrated in fiscal outcomes explained by national ideological measures rather than by localized preferences (Anzia 2021). How far the constraint reaches into the rest of local politics is still an open question.

Race organizes local politics whether or not it organizes local budgets. Race is the dominant cleavage in urban vote choice, ahead of class, ideology, and partisanship, and it matters most where minority candidates run and minority populations are large (Z. Hajnal and Trounstine 2014). Whether those votes produce officeholders depends on where a city's population is heading and not only on where it is, since demographic change shapes minority representation independently of current composition (Shah 2019). It also depends on electoral institutions. Converting from at-large to ward elections helps minority candidates where the group is large and geographically segregated (Abott and Magazinnik 2020). Who sits on a council is therefore a product of institutional design that varies city by city.

Race also structures what local governments produce. Segregated cities spend less on public goods, and segregation is associated with racial polarization in voting that divides what different groups want from their city (Trounstine 2016). Councils whose members come from different ethnic groups also spend less per capita on public goods than more homogeneous councils, a pattern read as gridlock among officials holding divergent group preferences (Beach and D. B. Jones 2017). That finding cuts against the expectation that minority representation improves group outcomes, and it belongs on the same side as the economic-constraint perspective. Race further shapes the local policies least legible as racial. Restrictive land use is supported by white communities protecting their property values and the public goods attached to them, so the segregation that follows is a policy outcome rather

than a market residue (Trounstine 2020). A council with no non-white members is not a council on which race is absent.

Work on local meetings themselves is newer and moving quickly, as minutes and transcripts have become a focus of political scientists. Residents who appear at planning and zoning meetings are older, have longer tenure, are more likely to be homeowners, and are relatively more active in local elections than the rest of the population. The preferences of these unrepresentative participants correlate strongly with what local governments end up approving (Einstein, Palmer, and Glick 2019; Sahn 2025). Local meetings are also arenas of conflict that officials try to manage. Conflict concentrates in a small number of high-intensity places and often involves cultural issues (M. Holman, Johnson, and Simko 2026), and officials respond with procedural tools to keep contested items from being taken up (M. R. Holman and Simko 2025). Agenda control is an exercise of power that local officials have in public meetings. These studies on local meetings have identified who gets into the room and how officials manage what the room takes up. What is still not established is what is said once a topic is taken up, which is the part of a meeting where representation would have to show itself.

Local government is a setting in which two well-supported bodies of work point in opposite directions. One side, the economic-constraint perspective, holds that a city's position in a competitive economy narrows what any council can do, that its politics is organized around services rather than groups, and that the identity of the people holding the seats is therefore close to incidental. The other, the racial-politics perspective, holds that race decides who votes for whom, that institutional rules decide whether minority candidates can win at all, that racial composition shapes what a city builds and what it spends, and that the meetings where all of this is worked out are neither open nor neutral.

Chapter 3

Theory of Race in Local Meetings

3.1 The Agenda

The agenda is the first place where the composition of a council could leave a mark. Before a city spends money, it decides what to spend it on, and before it decides that, someone has to raise the question. That step happens in public and on the record. It is also the step that neither the economic-constraint perspective nor the racial-politics perspective examines. The economic-constraint perspective is assembled from budgets and the racial-politics perspective is assembled from votes, institutional rules, and policy outcomes, and both treat the meeting as the place where a decision reached elsewhere gets ratified. A deliberative perspective rejects that description of the meeting. If representation in cities runs through discourse between officials and residents rather than through electoral accountability alone, and if a body's decisions are shaped by the discussion that produces them, then the meeting is where representation is worked out rather than where it is recorded (Collins 2018; Gutmann and Thompson 2004). I argue that this makes the agenda the earliest point at which representation becomes observable, and that the two accounts make opposite predictions about what happens there.

The accounts diverge more sharply at the agenda than at the budget. Peterson (1981)

describes a constraint that operates on money. A city that taxes and redistributes drives away the residents and businesses it competes for, so a council that wants to deliver to a group cannot pay for it. A council with little money for a program can still name a problem, hear from the residents it affects, direct staff to study it, or change a rule that costs nothing. Meetings do all of these things, and none of them draws on the tax base, so a constraint that operates on money does not reach the agenda on its own. The economic-constraint perspective therefore has to add something to cover the agenda, either that officials avoid raising questions they cannot answer, or that group-based concerns never reach the room at all. The first of those is plausible, but it is an assumption about how officials behave rather than a consequence of the fiscal constraint. The deliberative perspective predicts the reverse: what a body notices depends on who is in it, and noticing comes before paying (Mansbridge 1999).

This makes a null result at the agenda a stronger finding for the economic-constraint perspective than a null at the budget. A budget that does not move with composition is consistent with more than one story. A council may have wanted to deliver and been unable to pay, or it may have shifted resources within a fixed envelope in ways that spending categories do not record. A meeting that does not move with composition rules the first of those out, because attention is not rationed by the tax base in the way that money is. If composition does not change what a council is willing to take up, the constraint is not only fiscal, and it operates before the budget on what a council treats as its business. The reverse pattern is equally informative. Movement at the agenda alongside a null at the budget would locate the constraint where Peterson (1981) puts it, on delivery rather than on attention.

Swain's objection is different in kind, and the choice of outcome does not touch it. Moving from the budget to the agenda changes what is measured. It does not change the fact that a council's composition is produced by the city the council sits in, so a pattern at the agenda is exposed to the same confounding as a pattern at the budget. That objection has to be answered by design rather than by choice of outcome.

3.2 Mechanisms

The racial composition of a council could affect the content of its discussions through three mechanisms. The first is experiential knowledge. A city official who has lived with a problem recognizes it as a problem sooner, and that advantage is largest where a concern has not yet been formulated as a demand and so cannot be picked up by any official reading their constituents accurately (Mansbridge 1999; Broockman 2011). The second is intrinsic motivation. Minority officials invest in group interests in arenas that pay poorly in electoral terms, including extending help to constituents who cannot even vote for them and oversight work that attracts little notice (Broockman 2013; Minta 2009). Finally, descriptive representation raises participation and trust in local government, and council meetings are typically open to the public, so a council that represents different groups should be approached by a wider variety of residents (Bobo and Gilliam 1990; Barreto 2007; Heideman 2020; Collins 2018). The three operate at different points, on what an official notices, on what an official is willing to spend effort on, and on who comes to the meeting at all.

Alternatively, there are mechanisms that would lead to city council composition not having an effect on topics discussed in local meetings. The economic-constraint perspective suggests that the room a council has to act on identity-based interests is set by the city's competitive position rather than by who holds the seats, and economic imperatives play a large role in what cities spend their time on (Z. L. Hajnal and Trounstine 2010). Additionally, if group-relevant behavior is a response to the electorate that produced the official, then two officials of different races who face the same electorate should behave similarly, and the racial composition of city councils adds nothing on top of the needs and composition of the city (Swain 1993). Finally, the mobilization of meeting participants requires that a council representing different groups draws different residents to meetings. Previous evidence has shown that participation in local meetings is skewed towards homeowners, longtime residents, and frequent voters, and that composition is a function of who finds it worth showing up rather than a response to who holds office (Einstein, Palmer, and Glick 2019; Sahn 2025).

Along with officials having procedural control of meetings (M. R. Holman and Simko 2025), meeting participants would be staying the same and officials can hold the agenda steady. These mechanisms predict that meeting content tracks the city rather than the members on city councils.

3.3 Three Components

A council meeting moves through a series of subjects. Some arrive through officials and staff, and others are raised by residents who come to speak. Each subject carries discussion with it, and that discussion, rather than the decision it leads to, is what I take as the object of interest. A decision records what a council concluded. The discussion records what the council took up, whose concerns entered the room, and how those concerns were treated.

The literature on minority representation already separates two kinds of policy. Minta (2009) sorts minority-interest policy into two separate policy domains: issues framed explicitly in terms of race, such as civil rights and discrimination, and general social welfare issues that are not framed racially but fall disproportionately on minority communities. His result is asymmetric across the two domains. Black and Latino members participate more than white members in oversight of the explicitly racial domain and not in oversight of the general social welfare domain. That asymmetry is the reason to keep the domains apart rather than to collapse them into one measure.

Three questions follow from that distinction and from taking the discussion of a subject as the object of interest. The first is whether race is engaged in the discussion at all, which is the explicitly racial domain. The second is how race is engaged where it is engaged. Representation itself works in more than one way, since an official can mark the standing of a group and an official can act on that group's interests, and these are distinct attributes rather than degrees of one thing. The third returns to the general social welfare domain and asks which area of policy a discussion belongs to, whether or not race is engaged in it, since

a council can change what it works on without ever naming race. From this logic, I propose three components.

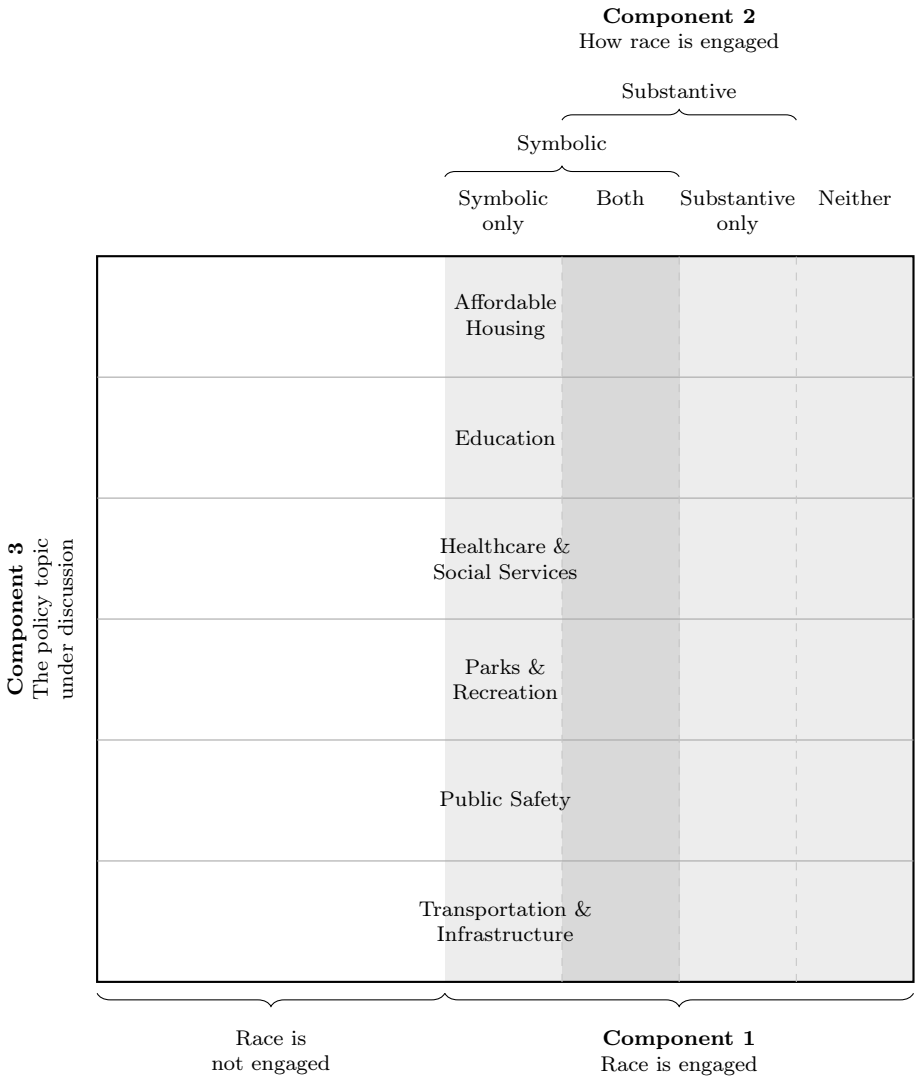
The first domain becomes Component 1, which records whether race is engaged at all. Component 2 distinguishes two separate axes. Speech is symbolic when its work is recognition, meaning it commemorates, honors, or ceremonially affirms a racial group, its history, or its standing in the community. A proclamation for Black History Month, a statement honoring a local civil-rights figure, and an affirmation that a city values its immigrant residents are symbolic in this sense (Dietrich and Hayes 2023; Vishwanath 2025). Naming a racial group is not by itself recognition, so a grievance, a complaint, or an observation that a condition falls on one group in particular is not symbolic. Speech is substantive when it ties a racial group or a racially framed concern to a concrete policy, resource, program, or decision, such as a funding choice, a regulatory choice, an enforcement practice, or a program directed at racial inequality (Minta 2009). A debate over whether a housing subsidy reaches Black residents is substantive whether or not the council approves it. The substantive marker is likewise narrower than substantive representation as the literature uses it. Substantive representation is a relationship between what a body does and what a group needs, and it is established by what a body enacts rather than by what it discusses (Pitkin 1967; Mansbridge 1999). A council can engage an action and never take it, and can take an action it never discussed, so this marker locates where substantive representation would become visible in a meeting without establishing that it followed. The symbolic marker is a property of what is said rather than a claim about what residents believe. It is narrower than symbolic representation in Pitkin (1967), which is a relationship constituted by the acceptance of the represented. These two axes are distinct qualities of speech rather than opposing endpoints of a single scale. Treating them as independent allows a stretch of speech to be symbolic, substantive, both, or neither.

Component 3 returns to Minta (2009)'s second domain and extends it. It measures policy attention, or the distribution of meeting content across policy areas independent of race.

Component 3 captures the possibility that descriptive representation reshapes local agendas without invoking race directly since minority officials can shift attention toward domains like housing, public safety, or community services that disproportionately affect their own neighborhoods. In the context of local governments, Component 3 uses six policy areas that account for much of a municipal budget: affordable housing, education, healthcare & social services, parks & recreation, public safety, and transportation & infrastructure. Unlike Component 2, Component 3 is not nested inside Component 1 and is measured across all meeting content, since a council can prioritize what it works on without ever naming race.

The three components describe different parts of the same meeting, and Figure 3.1 sets out how they fit together. Component 3 divides everything a council discusses, since every subject taken up belongs to some area of policy. Component 1 marks the part of that discussion where race is engaged, and it can arise under any policy area rather than forming an area of its own. Component 2 applies only inside that part, since how race is engaged is a question that can be asked only where race is engaged at all. Because the two qualities of Component 2 are separate rather than opposite, a discussion that engages race can be symbolic, substantive, both, or neither. A discussion is both when a council marks the standing of a group and engages an action at the same time, as when a commemoration carries a commitment to enforcement. A discussion is neither when race enters without recognition and without any action for the council to take, as when a speaker observes that a problem falls on one group in particular. The last of these is not a residue left over by the other three. It follows from asking two independent questions of the same discussion, and it names the discussions that engage race descriptively without marking the standing of a group and without engaging what a council can do.

Figure 3.1: Diagram of Components



The rectangle represents everything a council discusses in a meeting. The figure is a schematic and the areas do not represent quantities.

3.4 Hypotheses

The predictions below are stated in terms of the racial composition of the council. Composition is where the two perspectives disagree, it varies across cities and within cities over time, and it is the quantity the mechanisms on both sides are about. Each prediction is about the content of a meeting rather than about the behavior of any individual official, since what a

body attends to is produced jointly by everyone in the room.

The first prediction is the most direct test of whether composition reaches local meetings, and it concerns the cheapest thing composition could move. Raising race in a discussion costs a council nothing, so the experiential and mobilization mechanisms both predict an effect here before they predict one anywhere else.

Race is not absent from an all-white council. Mendelberg and Oleske (2000) finds that a racially homogeneous meeting can advance one group's interest in universal language that names no group and still sounds reasonable to everyone present, and that the same language is heard as racial by a mixed audience. Race can therefore be present in the substance of what a council discusses while going unnamed in how the council discusses it. What composition should change is how often race is named rather than whether race is at stake. Adding non-white members changes who is in the room to hear the argument, which makes unnamed racial framing harder to sustain, and each mechanism separately raises the chance that someone treats race as relevant enough to name. An official who has lived with a problem recognizes it sooner, an official who shares the concern is more willing to spend effort on it, and a wider range of residents comes to the meeting to raise it. Each of those runs at a lower rate on an all-white council rather than at zero.

> **H1**: An increase in the non-white share of a city council increases the share of meeting content that engages race.

A positive result is consistent with non-white officials raising race, with white officials raising it less, or with both. A null is what the economic-constraint perspective predicts, since economic imperatives leave little room for race in council meetings.

The second set of predictions asks whether councils with more non-white members talk about race in different ways, not only more often. How often a council raises race does not settle how it raises it. A council that rarely engages race may do so almost entirely in recognition, and a council that engages race often may do it substantively and symbolically,

so a difference in how much racial content a council produces implies nothing on its own about the composition of that content. The two predictions below are therefore claims about what a more non-white council adds to the racial agenda relative to what is already on it. The two axes of Component 2 are independent, so race-engaging content can be symbolic, substantive, both, or neither. The two shares below are therefore not complements, and either, both, or neither prediction can hold. Each is stated as a share of race-engaging content, which measures how race is handled once it is raised, and each is also reported as a share of all meeting content, which measures how much of the agenda consists of symbolic or substantive language. **H2a** holds if what a more non-white council adds is more heavily commemorative than what is already there. Recognition costs a council nothing, and minority officials are observed engaging racial issues through commemoration, affirmation, and reference to civil-rights history (Dietrich and Hayes 2023; Vishwanath 2025). **H2b** holds if what it adds engages more often with an action a council can take, which is what the experiential mechanism predicts, since shared experience surfaces as concrete engagement with what a city could do rather than as recognition alone (Mansbridge 1999; Minta 2009).

> **H2a**: An increase in the non-white share of a city council increases the share of race-engaging content that is symbolic.
>
> **H2b**: An increase in the non-white share of a city council increases the share of race-engaging content that is substantive.

The economic-constraint perspective does not predict a null on both axes. A constraint that operates on what a city can deliver leaves recognition free, so it predicts movement on **H2a** without movement on **H2b**.

The third set of predictions asks whether composition reorders the rest of the agenda, the part that is not explicitly about race. Policies that are not framed racially still fall unevenly on minority communities, and officials whose communities carry that weight should give them more attention. The three predictions come from a survey I conducted and discuss

in the next section, which asked respondents their priorities across the municipal budget items that define Component 3. White and non-white respondents differ on four of the six categories, and on three of those four every group inside the non-white category moves in the same direction as the difference. Those three are affordable housing, public safety, and transportation & infrastructure. Healthcare & social services shows a difference that rests on one group rather than on all three, so it carries no prediction. Using those gaps as predictions about council meetings assumes that officials and residents carry the priorities of their group into meetings, which is the assumption the experiential and mobilization mechanisms make.

> **H3a**: An increase in the non-white share of a city council increases the share of meeting content devoted to affordable housing.
>
> **H3b**: An increase in the non-white share of a city council decreases the share of meeting content devoted to public safety.
>
> **H3c**: An increase in the non-white share of a city council decreases the share of meeting content devoted to transportation and infrastructure.

Movement on **H1** together with movement on **H3** would mean composition affects both the racial and the general agenda, which is the strongest form of the deliberative perspective and the hardest for the economic-constraint perspective to absorb. Movement on **H1** and **H2a** without **H2b** or **H3** would mean composition changes recognition without changing what a council works on, which is what the constraint predicts if it binds on substance and leaves symbol free. Movement on **H3** without **H1** would mean composition reorders priorities without racializing the discussion, which fits an account in which officials pursue group interests in terms that do not name the group. A null across all of them would mean that what a council talks about does not depend on who sits on it. That is a substantive finding rather than an absence of one, and it is the one that most favors the economic-constraint perspective. These predictions, and **H3** most directly, rest on a premise about what racial groups want from a city government, which the next section measures directly

rather than assumes.

Chapter 4

Racial Differences in Local Policy Preferences

Anzia (2021) identifies a measurement gap at the center of the study of local public opinion. A lot of studies have concluded that local politics resembles national/state politics in being organized by partisanship and ideology, and Anzia argues that this conclusion is premature. The preferences behind previous studies are preferences over national policy questions, and city governments mostly do other things. Whether opinion about those functions is organized the way opinion about national policy is organized cannot be settled with measures built from national policy items (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014). The evidence that speaks to the question directly does not close it either, since attitudes toward many local issues reflect the same latent dimension that national policy attitudes do while a smaller set looks distinctively local (Schaffner, Rhodes, and La Raja 2026). Which local issues behave like national ones is therefore an empirical matter to be settled issue by issue, and settling it requires asking about local government functions directly.

That measurement has been organized around ideology and partisanship rather than around race. This is a gap for the argument in this paper, which runs through group priorities rather than ideological ones. If the racial composition of a council changes what

the council attends to, one reason is that the officials and residents who make up a racial group carry different priorities into the room, and that premise is usually assumed rather than measured. Race is the dominant cleavage in urban vote choice, and segregation is associated with racial polarization in local elections (Z. Hajnal and Trounstine 2014; Trounstine 2016). Both findings show that racial groups divide politically in cities. Neither shows what those groups want a city budget to do.

The survey reported here asks that question directly. In the fall of 2024, I co-fielded a nationally representative survey through YouGov with one thousand respondents. Table 4.1 reports the composition of the sample. Of those respondents, 681 identified as white, 121 as Black, 114 as Hispanic, and 27 as Asian. The remaining 57 identified as Native American, as two or more races, as Middle Eastern, or as another category.

Table 4.1: Survey sample composition by respondent race

Race	N	Unweighted %	Weighted %
White	681	68.1%	66.6%
Black	121	12.1%	12.5%
Hispanic	114	11.4%	11.4%
Asian	27	2.7%	3.3%
Native American	9	0.9%	1.1%
Two or more races	21	2.1%	2.0%
Other	22	2.2%	2.6%
Middle Eastern	5	0.5%	0.6%
Total	1,000	100.0%	100.0%

Respondents answered two questions about local policy preferences. The first was open-ended:

> *"What issues related to your city government or city policies do you personally consider most important?"*

The second asked respondents to divide a fixed budget across six categories:

> *Imagine you have $100 to allocate across different areas in your city's budget. You can distribute these funds however you like. For example, you can allocate everything to*

one area, divide it equally, or choose any other distribution that reflects your priorities. How would you distribute these funds among the following areas?

Public Safety (Police and Fire Departments)

Healthcare & Social Services (Public Health Clinics, Emergency Services, Support for Vulnerable Populations)

Education (Libraries, Schools, Arts Programs)

Transportation & Infrastructure (Roads, Bike Lanes, and Public Transit)

Affordable Housing (Subsidies and Housing Projects)

Parks & Recreation (Parks, Green Spaces, Recreation Centers)

The allocation item is a fixed budget. Respondents divide one hundred dollars across the six categories, and the amounts sum to one hundred, so no respondent can ask for more spending overall. Every difference the item can record is a difference in the ranking of one category against the others. A larger allocation to one category has to be paid for by smaller allocations elsewhere, which is worth holding onto when reading any single gap below.

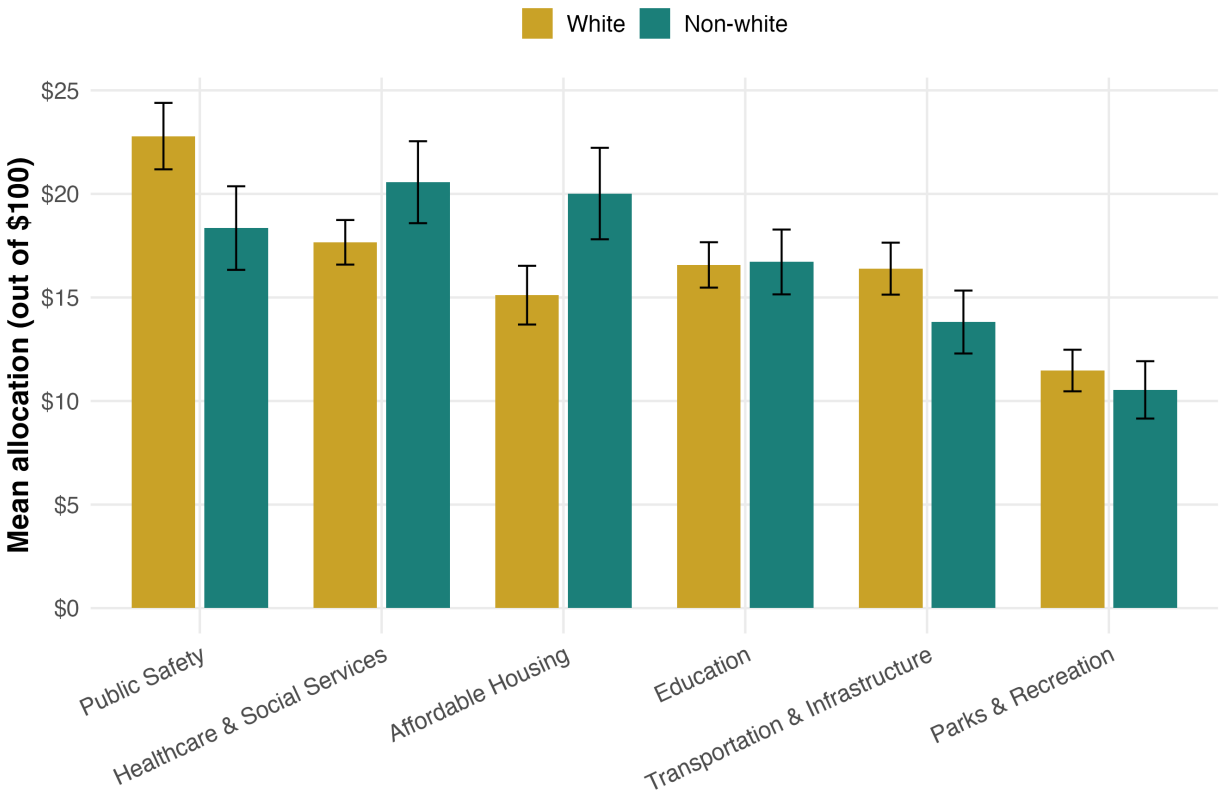
The open-ended item shows that respondents have local priorities available to them without being prompted. Of the one thousand respondents, 920 gave a substantive answer, and the answers named specific local matters rather than national controversies. Shown in Table 4.2, the words most distinctive of each group's responses point in different directions. White respondents disproportionately wrote about taxes, infrastructure, growth, the economy, and drugs. Non-white respondents disproportionately wrote about prices, affordable housing, security, and climate. The white list is organized around what a city costs and what it builds. The non-white list is organized around what living in the city costs. What the two lists show is that white and non-white respondents reach for different aspects of local government when nothing constrains the answer.

Table 4.2: Words most distinctive of white and non-white open-ended responses, ranked by weighted log-odds with a uniform prior. Counts are pooled tokens and are not survey-weighted. The five words shown per group are a display choice

Rank	White	Non-white
1	taxes	prices
2	infrastructure	affordable
3	growth	housing
4	economy	security
5	drugs	climate

The allocation item measures the same priorities under a constraint. Pooling all respondents, public safety takes the largest average allocation at $21.30 and parks & recreation takes the smallest at $11.20. The two groups agree on the bottom of that ranking and not on the top. Public safety is the largest allocation among white respondents at $22.80, and healthcare & social services is the largest among non-white respondents at $20.60. The group differences reported in Figure 4.1 are differences around that shared ranking.

Figure 4.1: Mean Budget Allocation by Respondent Race



Mean allocation of a fixed one hundred dollar budget across six categories, survey-weighted, with 95 percent confidence intervals. Categories are ordered by the pooled mean. The budget is fixed, so the six means sum to one hundred dollars within each group.

Non-white and white respondents differ on four of the six categories. Table 4.3 reports each difference with a 95 percent interval. Affordable housing and public safety carry the two largest differences, at $4.91 more and $4.44 less. Healthcare & social services follows at $2.90 more and transportation & infrastructure at $2.58 less. All four of those intervals exclude zero. Education and parks & recreation are close to flat and both of their intervals contain zero. The table reports the same six differences under a second definition of the non-white category, restricted to Black, Hispanic, and Asian respondents, and the two definitions agree on the ordering and on which intervals exclude zero. Because the budget is fixed, the six differences sum to zero. Non-white respondents move money out of public safety, transportation & infrastructure, and parks & recreation and into affordable housing and

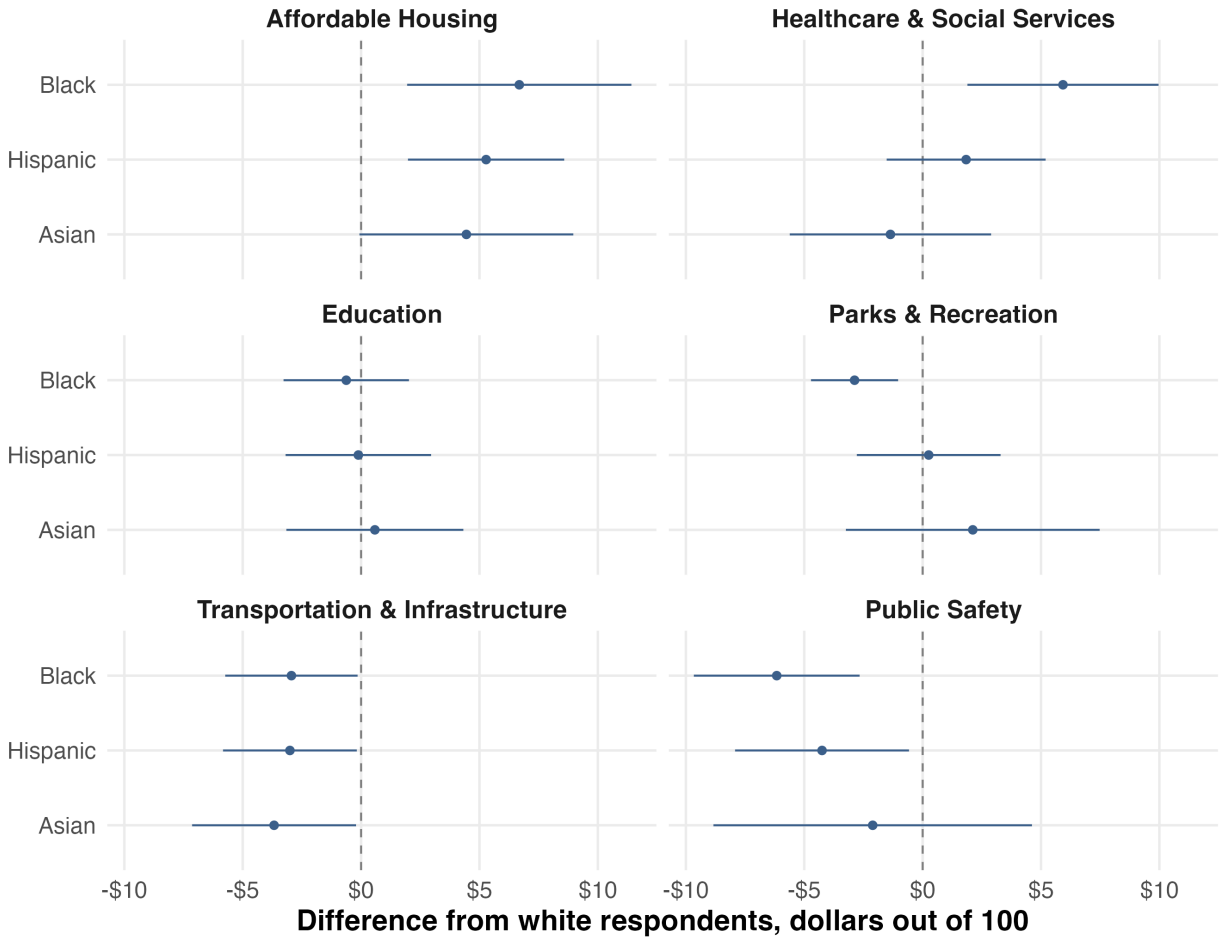
healthcare & social services.

Table 4.3: Non-white minus white difference in mean budget allocation, survey-weighted, with 95 percent confidence intervals. The first pair of columns uses every respondent who is not white (n = 1,000). The second uses Black, Hispanic and Asian respondents only (n = 943). Differences are in dollars out of 100 and sum to zero within each pair

Category	Gap, all non-white	Interval, all non-white	Gap, Black Hispanic Asian	Interval, Black Hispanic Asian
Affordable Housing	+4.91	[+2.28, +7.53]	+5.82	[+2.96, +8.68]
Healthcare & Social Services	+2.90	[+0.65, +5.15]	+3.33	[+0.78, +5.88]
Education	+0.14	[-1.77, +2.05]	-0.27	[-2.28, +1.75]
Parks & Recreation	-0.93	[-2.64, +0.78]	-0.96	[-2.81, +0.90]
Transportation & Infrastructure	-2.58	[-4.55, -0.61]	-3.06	[-5.10, -1.02]
Public Safety	-4.44	[-7.02, -1.86]	-4.87	[-7.56, -2.18]

Pooling non-white respondents into a single category holds on the three categories that carry predictions. Figure 4.2 reports each group's difference from white respondents separately. On affordable housing, public safety, and transportation & infrastructure, all nine differences run in the direction of the pooled difference, and seven of the nine intervals exclude zero. The two that do not are both Asian, and the Asian subsample is 27 respondents, so the agreement is established firmly for Black and Hispanic respondents and weakly for Asian respondents. Healthcare & social services does not hold together the same way. Black respondents allocate $5.93 more than white respondents with an interval excluding zero, Hispanic respondents allocate $1.84 more, and Asian respondents allocate $1.36 less. The pooled difference on healthcare rests on one group rather than on three.

Figure 4.2: Budget Allocation Differences from White Respondents, by Group



Difference in mean budget allocation between each non-white group and white respondents, six categories, survey-weighted, with 95 percent confidence intervals. Differences are in dollars out of 100.

The two survey questions agree on housing, and they agree without being asked to. The allocation question names affordable housing as one of the six options and produces the largest gap there. The open-ended question doesn't name any policy area and finds that non-white respondents raise housing, affordability, and prices on their own. A difference that survives both a prompted and an unprompted format is harder to attribute to the categories the question supplied. However, the difference comes with a caveat the survey cannot resolve. A stated budget priority is not the same as support for a particular development. Homeowners oppose local housing development even when their general ideological

commitments point the other way, and the cross-pressure between a general preference and a proximate interest is strongest where housing is concerned (Marble and Nall 2021). That finding is about ideology and homeownership rather than about race, so it does not predict that the difference measured here would reverse. It does mean that a group that allocates more of a hypothetical budget to affordable housing may still divide over a specific project, and a council responding to that group could face demands that point in opposite directions. The allocation format cannot distinguish the two. What it measures is the priority a respondent assigns to housing against the other things a city does.

There are two limits with this survey that should be stated in the context of the paper. First, this survey is a national sample of adults and doesn't necessarily include a sample of the cities that I analyze in the following sections. On top of that, it may not even match the people who attend city council meetings, since meeting participants are known to be unrepresentative of the places where they live (Einstein, Palmer, and Glick 2019; Sahn 2025). With this, it is important to be cautious about inferring that these preferences match those of city officials and meeting participants. Additionally, the survey measures demand and preferences rather than capacity. The economic-constraint account is a claim about what a city can deliver, not about what residents want, so the survey evidence doesn't count against it.

The survey establishes a premise rather than a finding about councils. Racial groups differ in what they want a city to prioritize, and that difference is the condition under which the racial composition of a council could change what the council attends to. The condition holds. Whether councils act on it is a question about councils rather than about respondents, and no survey of residents can answer it. Answering it requires observing what councils actually discuss, across cities whose councils differ in racial composition. The remainder of the paper takes up that evidence, using transcripts of city council meetings and records of the councils that held them. The six categories the survey asked about are used to classify the topics that city councils discuss, so the priorities measured here and the

attention measured there are stated in common terms.

Chapter 5

Data

The first dataset I rely on is LocalView, which supplies transcripts of local meetings along with the 2018 ACS estimates of a city's population and racial composition. LocalView takes advantage of local governments posting their meetings on YouTube and collects transcripts from YouTube's generated captions (Barari and Simko 2023). For this project, I keep meetings held by city councils, though LocalView includes meetings for other bodies as well. The transcripts do not carry speaker attribution, so the measures record what was said in a meeting and not who said it. Council members, staff, and public commenters are pooled into a single record, which means that no estimate in this paper identifies a change in official behavior on its own and that the mechanisms cannot be separated from one another.

The second dataset I use is the American Local Government Elections Database, which contains election results for municipal offices across the country along with the estimated racial, party, and gender composition of city councils (Benedictis-Kessner, Lee, et al. 2023). Composition is estimated rather than self-reported, so the independent variable is a classification itself rather than a record of how councilmembers identify.

The two datasets were assembled independently, so the analysis is limited to the cities that appear in both. LocalView contributes city council meetings for 948 cities between 2006 and 2023. The elections database contributes city council composition for 480 cities

between 1989 and 2021. Table 5.1 illustrates that joining the two datasets leaves 123 cities where a council's composition and its meeting records are together. Restricting to cities where I classify meeting content leaves 112 cities and 719 city-years. Appendix A traces that attrition in full and reports coverage for the full corpus alongside the classified sample. The appendix also reports the composition of the survey sample before and after weighting.

Table 5.1: Cities, city-years, and meetings at each step from the two raw sources to the base the analyses run on. The first two rows are separate sources rather than nested restrictions. Blank cells are quantities a row does not carry, since the elections database holds no meetings and a composition restriction does not define a meeting count

Step	Cities	City-years	Meetings
LocalView corpus	948	5,662	119,897
Elections database	480	3,123	
Cities in both	123	277	
Classified sample	112	719	8,825
With observed council composition	92	223	

Council composition is observed for a subset of those city-years rather than for all of them. The elections database records composition on the election cycle, and most cities hold council elections every two years, so a council seated in one year does not appear again in the record until the next contest. Within the sample, composition is observed in 223 of the 719 city-years, across 92 of the 112 cities, with a median of two observed years per city. Every analysis that relates meeting content to council composition runs on those 223 city-years. The unit of analysis throughout is the city-year, and meetings are pooled within a city-year to form each outcome.

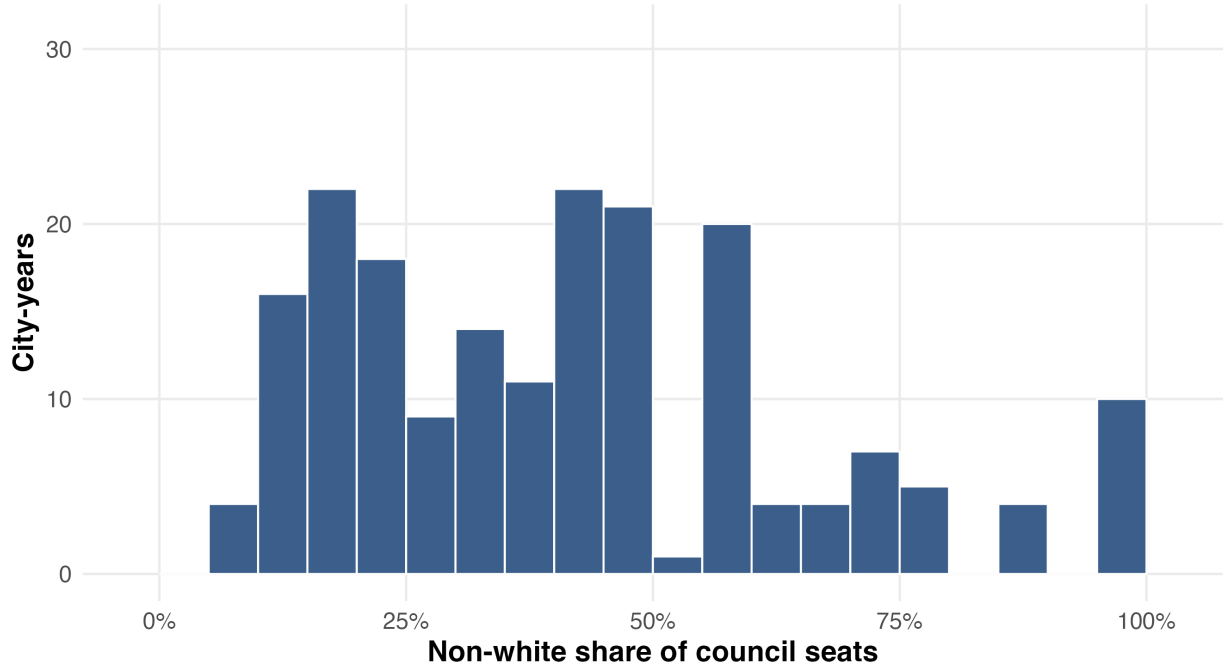
The cities that survive this construction are far larger and far less white than the corpus they are drawn from. Table 5.2 reports that the LocalView corpus has a median population of 13,706 and is 31.6% non-white on average across cities. The cities where city council composition is available in addition to the meeting transcripts have a median population of 135,985 and are 53.7% non-white. The sample therefore describes city councils in mid-sized and large cities across the United States.

Table 5.2: City size and racial composition at three stages of the sample. Population is a median because the distribution is right skewed and a mean would be set by a few large cities. The racial shares are means across cities, so each city counts once regardless of size. City demographics come from the ACS estimates LocalView carries, so the comparison is internal to the corpus and does not describe American cities generally

Group	Cities	Median population	Mean white %	Mean non-white %
Full corpus	948	13,706	68.4%	31.6%
Cities with composition	123	135,985	46.3%	53.7%
Analysis sample	112	138,616	46.5%	53.5%

The first independent variable that comes from the combined dataset is the non-white share of a city council in a given year. Figure 5.1 shows the full distribution of council composition along with Table 5.3. Council composition varies widely across the sample. The sample spans 33 states and the mean council is 36.9% non-white.

Figure 5.1: Distribution of Council Non-White Share



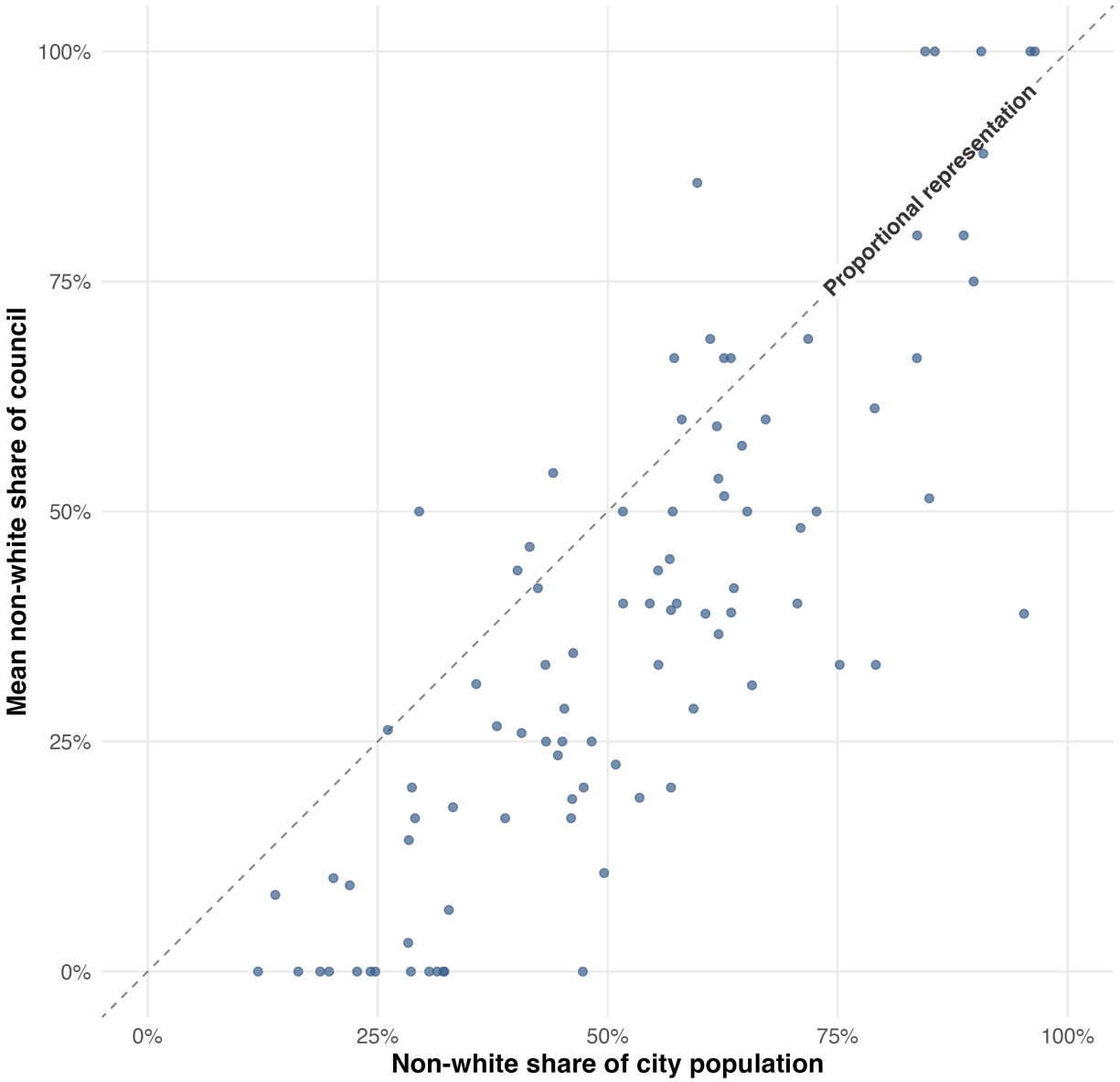
City-years by the non-white share of council seats with a known race. Bins are five percentage points wide. The base is the city-years with an observed council.

Table 5.3: Council racial composition across the city-years where it is observed. Percentages of a share are reported on the same scale as the share itself

Quantity	Value
City-years with observed composition	223
Cities	92
Median observed years per city	2
Mean council non-white share	36.9%
City-years with no non-white members	13.9%
City-years with a non-white majority	24.7%
Standard deviation across cities	27.4%
Standard deviation within cities	9.4%
Cities observed in more than one year	58
Of those, share recording any change	69.0%
Mean share of seats with an estimated race	90.4%

Council racial composition is highly responsive to city racial composition, but with a consistent downward bias in non-white council share. Figure 5.2 plots each city's mean council non-white share against its non-white population share, with a diagonal marking proportional descriptive representation. In this sample, 82.6% of cities sit below the line, where the average council is 15 percentage points less non-white than its city, so underrepresentation is close to universal rather than confined to a subset of places.

Figure 5.2: Council Composition Against City Composition



One point per city with observed composition, plotting the mean non-white share of the council against the non-white share of the city population. The dashed diagonal marks proportional representation. The two axes share a scale.

I group cities into three different types based on their compositions. A city is majority-white when white residents are at least half the population, majority-minority when one non-white group is at least half, and multiracial when no group consists of more than half of

the population. This follows grouping used to study representation across demographically different cities (Shah 2019). The 112 cities in the classified sample divide into 50 majority-white, 22 majority-minority, and 40 multiracial cities.

Chapter 6

Measurement

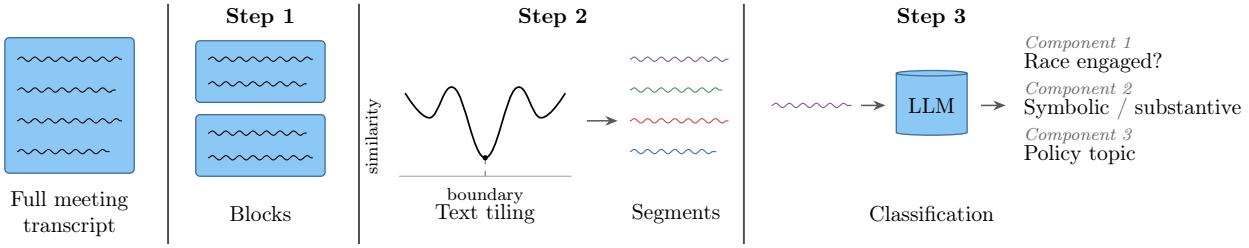
6.1 Segmentation

To classify meeting transcripts, I first start by cutting each transcript into topically coherent segments. LocalView provides meeting transcripts as a single block of automatic captions with no punctuation, speaker labels, or agendas. A council meeting that spends ten minutes of a two-hour meeting on a fair housing ordinance is not usefully described as just one observation. The unit throughout the text classification is a segment, a stretch of transcript that stays on one subject. Segmenting is what makes it possible to ask what share of a meeting engages race rather than only whether a meeting mentions race at all.

Figure 6.1 diagrams the pipeline from a raw transcript to the three components. Each transcript is divided into consecutive blocks of forty words, each block is embedded with an OpenAI embedding model, and the cosine similarity between consecutive blocks produces a similarity sequence across the meeting. A change of subject appears as a valley in that sequence. The depth of a valley is how far similarity falls below the nearest higher point on each side, summed across the two sides, so a gap counts as deep when it sits below its surroundings in both directions rather than only one. Candidate boundaries are the local minima of the sequence, and a candidate becomes a boundary when its depth exceeds the

mean depth among candidates in that meeting less half a standard deviation. The threshold is meeting-relative rather than fixed across the corpus, so a meeting whose subjects shift gradually is cut on the same terms as one whose subjects shift sharply. No cut is made before a segment reaches sixty words, and a cut is forced once a segment passes 250 words. I modeled this procedure after Hearst (1997), using embedding similarity instead of lexical overlaps. Through this method, I am left with 697,744 segments across 8,825 meetings.

Figure 6.1: The Text Analysis Pipeline



Wavy lines stand for transcript text, and color distinguishes one segment from the next rather than marking any property of a segment. The curve in Step 2 is the similarity between neighboring blocks across a meeting, and the marked valley is a cut point. The diagram is illustrative and is not drawn from any particular meeting.

The resulting segments are short enough to carry a single subject and numerous enough to describe a meeting. The median segment holds 160 words and the middle half of segments run from 120 to 240 words. Of the 8,825 meetings, the median divides into 66 segments. These meetings don't constitute all the meetings in the sample since I imposed a cap of 20 meetings per city-year to lower costs. I drew a random sample of 20 meetings per city-year (if there were more than 20) to preserve every city-year in the panel, and this cap binds in 290 of the 719 city-years.

A substantial portion of boundaries are placed by a length rule rather than by a change of subject, and those boundaries cut through discussion that had not ended. Of the 688,919 boundaries the algorithm places, 81% fall where the discussion shifts and 19% are placed because the segment ran over 250 words. Where the algorithm finds a shift, the text on either side of the boundary has a median similarity of 0.328. Where the length rule decides the boundary, the median similarity is 0.412, so the text on either side is more alike. This means

that a long discussion of one subject can stretch through multiple segments. A share of segments gives more weight to a topic a council stayed on than to a topic a council discussed once, which is a property of the measure. A share of segments should not be interpreted as a share of speaking time. Appendix B records the segmentation parameters in full and reports the table these shares are computed from.

6.2 Classification

Each segment is sent to a large language model, which returns a policy category, an identity category, positions toward a group, and two markers for substantive or symbolic speech. For Component 1, which is measured by a segment engaging race, the LLM classified 5.4% of segments as engaging race within the frame. With the broader identity category, which counts any identity content rather than race alone, the model classified 10% of segments as engaging with identities such as gender, sexual orientation, and veteran status. Table 6.1 gives the split across 37,604 race-engaging segments for Component 2, which identifies how race is engaged. Of race-engaging segments, 43.3% are substantive only, 8.9% are symbolic only, and 0.8% are classified as both.

Both markers are set by explicit criteria rather than by a judgment about tone. The symbolic marker is set only when a segment commemorates, honors, recognizes, or ceremonially affirms a group, as in a heritage-month proclamation or a land acknowledgment. Ceremony that is not about an identity group, such as an invocation or a memorial for an individual, does not set it, and neither does a grievance, a complaint, a lawsuit, or a demographic observation. The substantive marker is set only when a segment ties a group or a group-framed concern to a concrete policy, resource, program, or decision, as in funding language access for immigrant residents or debating policing in racial terms. General policy discussion that is not about a group, such as a sewer line or retiree insurance, does not set it. The criteria do not require the policy at issue to lie within the council's own authority, so a discussion

of state or federal action bearing on a racial group sets the marker as well. The two markers are evaluated independently, so a segment can set both, one, or neither. Appendix B gives the classification prompt, the ten judgments each model call returned, and the eleven identity categories the model could assign. It also documents the gate that decides which of those categories count as racial, which is what makes the size of the exclusion visible rather than leaving it inside the classifier. Immigration is the one conditional category, in frame only where no group is named and the stance is not hostile, and a named group always takes precedence over it. A hostile segment about a named group stays race-engaging, since excluding it would make the measure record only favorable attention.

Table 6.1: Classifier output across classified segments. The four combination rows are mutually exclusive and sum to Component 1. The confidence row and the two rows below those four overlap them

Quantity	Segments	Share of classified	Share of race-engaging
Classified segments	697,391		
Any identity content	69,533	9.97%	
Engages race (Component 1)	37,604	5.39%	
Below high confidence	9,756	1.40%	25.9%
Substantive only	16,293	2.34%	43.3%
Symbolic only	3,358	0.48%	8.9%
Both	285	0.04%	0.8%
Neither	17,668	2.53%	47.0%
Any substantive	16,578	2.38%	44.1%
Any symbolic	3,643	0.52%	9.7%

Component 3 was measured by the model classifying which of the six categories from the survey a segment was referencing, plus a residual category for everything else. The residual is large by construction, at 49.5% of classified content. The six categories better describe budgeting items, so items such as zoning, personnel, licensing, and ceremonial items are typically classified as residual. Table 6.2 reports the mix of classified segments as a share of all classified content and also renormalized among the segments that actually were classified as a policy category. Transportation & Infrastructure is the most frequently classified of the six categories while Healthcare & Social Services is the smallest.

Table 6.2: Policy topic mix across classified content segments

Topic	Segments	Share of all	Share of policy-coded
None / residual	345,319	49.5%	
Transportation & Infrastructure	87,509	12.5%	24.9%
Public Safety	69,638	10.0%	19.8%
Affordable Housing	68,795	9.9%	19.5%
Education	46,637	6.7%	13.2%
Parks & Recreation	44,376	6.4%	12.6%
Healthcare & Social Services	35,117	5.0%	10.0%

6.3 Validation

The findings from the classification process rely on judgments a language model made about text. The model read each segment, decided whether race was engaged, and classified the content of the segment according to a prompt it was given. No other individual reviewed those decisions at scale, and no independent record of what a council was actually talking about exists, so there is no external criterion the labels can be measured against. None of the checks below can establish that the labels are correct. Each rules out a specific way the measure could be broken, and together they establish that the classifier ran as specified, that its output does not depend on which meetings were drawn, and that it moves when there is an outside reason to expect movement.

Every segment sent to the model returned a valid classification. Segmentation produced 697,744 segments, and 353 were set aside by the content gate as procedural before anything was classified. All 697,391 remaining segments returned a valid classification, so every denominator in the analysis counts successful classifications rather than attempts.

One of the model's judgments is verified against the transcript itself, and the verification can only remove readings rather than add them. The LLM may record that a segment engages race without naming a group, and when it does it must quote the phrase in the segment that leads to that judgment. The quoted phrase is then searched for in the segment,

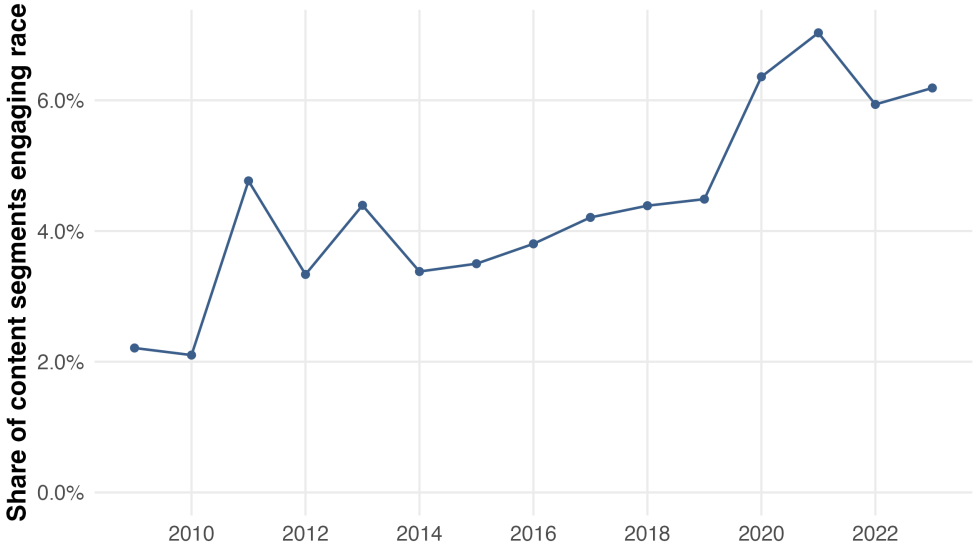
and if it does not appear the reading is discarded. The model recorded 4,631 phrases and found that 510 of them, or 11%, did not appear, and those readings were discarded. What this bounds is one specific failure, a model asserting an implicit reading with no text behind it, and the check can only make Component 1 smaller. It says nothing about explicit calls, which are not verified this way, and nothing about race-engaging content the model failed to record at all.

Whatever error the measure contains is concentrated in race-engaging content rather than spread evenly across the corpus. The model returns a certainty level with every segment, and 92.5% of classified segments come back at high certainty. Race is engaged in 4.32% of high-certainty segments and 18.6% of medium-certainty ones, so race-engaging content is drawn disproportionately from the segments the model was least sure about. This bears on Component 1 more than on anything built from the full corpus, and it does not sign the error. The classifier could be assigning race too readily in the segments it is unsure about, or missing it, and this comparison does not separate the two.

A city-year's use of racial language is computed from a sample of that city-year's meetings, so the result depends on which meetings were drawn. Meetings are the unit that was drawn at random under the cap, which makes them the unit to resample. I split each city-year's meetings into two halves and compared the share of the use of racial language between both halves. With this exercise, I found that across 637 city-years with at least two meetings, the reliability is 0.615. Among the 552 city-years with at least four meetings it is 0.805, 0.800 at six meetings, 0.810 at ten, and 0.803 at twenty. Reliability rises to four meetings and is flat above it, so four meetings is the point beyond which drawing more meetings buys nothing this test can detect, and the twenty-meeting cap costs nothing either. What is affected is noise at the bottom of the panel. There are 167 city-years carrying fewer than four meetings, 23.2% of the panel, and 82 of those carry a single meeting. A classifier that mislabels consistently would mislabel both halves the same way and score just as high, so these findings primarily speak to stability rather than correctness.

The measure also moves when there is an outside reason to expect it to. Figure 6.2 reports the share of classified content engaging race in each year of the corpus. The share sits between three and five percent through 2019 and steps up to 6.4% in 2020, staying near that level through 2023. The corpus is not the same set of cities in every year, so that series on its own cannot separate a change in what councils said from a change in which councils were recorded. Restricting to the 57 cities with at least four meetings in both 2019 and 2020, which is the same floor the split-half exercise sets, 40 raise their race-engaging share, and the median city rises by 1.10 percentage points. This is face validity and not a finding about 2020, since many meetings were also moved online that year and the composition of the corpus changed substantially.

Figure 6.2: Race-Language by Year



Share of classified content segments engaging race, by meeting year. The corpus covers a different set of cities in each year, so this series describes the corpus rather than a fixed panel of councils.

Below are five segments that were randomly drawn from different categories and then selected for length and clarity. The first is an example of a segment that was classified as engaging race and as using race substantively:

Public safety. Race engaged. Substantive, not symbolic.

gun violence and we haven't said that word today that is the second amendment okay if we go back and look at the history of our country it becomes very very clear that the second amendment was demanded by the southern states so people that they have enslaved african-americans in particular could be controlled i think it is time for us to have a conversation about gutting the second amendment itself

The second example mentions race and is classified as using race symbolically. This segment does not have a policy topic, which is where most commemorative content lands:

No policy category. Race engaged. Symbolic, not substantive.

whereas Juneteenth also known as emancipation day commemorates the observance of the end of slavery in the United States and is observed annually on June 19th and whereas in Galveston Texas on June 19 1865 Major General Gordon Granger announced the end of both the Civil War and slavery saying the people of Texas are informed that in accordance with a proclamation from the executive of the United States all slaves are free

The third segment carries both symbolic and substantive language. This can happen in cases where people attach enforcement to commemorative proclamations as shown here:

Affordable housing. Race engaged. Both symbolic and substantive.

whereas the city is committed to providing equal housing opportunities to all residents through the enforcement of the Federal Fair Housing Act and the fair housing ordinance of the city and whereas housing discrimination incidents continue to be reported in spite of the local and national efforts to eradicate unlawful discriminatory practices now therefore I do hereby proclaim the month of April 2018 as fair housing month

The fourth example segment mentions a racial group, but was not classified as either symbolic or substantive.

Healthcare and social services. Race engaged. Neither symbolic nor substantive.

certainly for sickle cell disease and wanting to make sure because that certainly is a disease that touches people of color and it has certainly not been a disease that there's been a lot of work around that particular illness and so certainly want to make sure I state my comments about the importance of that disease that's still within the african-american community

This fifth example does not engage race and carries a policy topic, which is the most common case:

Education. Race not engaged.

Paredes Elementary if you will recall at Paredes we had a situation where there's ten Portable Buildings and what was happening is when they were built many years ago they were built in a location where water remained stagnant and so every year when it rained the water would remain there it would start evaporating and then the floors came apart we literally have ten portable buildings with holes in the flooring because of the corrosion

The first three segments are cases the classification handles without strain. The fourth is the case that produces the neither category. A speaker naming a disease that falls disproportionately on a racial group is engaging race without commemorating anything and without tying the group to a policy, resource, or program. A speaker linking the second amendment to slavery is engaging race and arguing about policy (even though the policy is not exactly enforced by local governments). A Juneteenth proclamation is engaging race and using symbolic language. A fair housing proclamation does both at once. These segments should also highlight the ambiguity behind the task given to the model. Race can be discussed in so many ways, explicitly or implicitly, and accompanied by so many symbols and references that it can be difficult for an LLM to make so many decisions with one segment of text. Appendix C sets the classifier against a second instrument, a dictionary of race terms applied to the same segments, and the two agree only in part. The model calls race in 52.2% of the segments the dictionary flags, and 60.9% of the segments the model calls

race-engaging contain a dictionary term. Neither instrument is a criterion for the other. A word list cannot separate a race from a footrace or an equity stake from racial equity, and the model records race-engaging content that names no race term at all. The classifications carry enough weight to describe what councils spend their meetings on and to compare cities and years against one another, but establishing that an individual label is correct would require hand-labeled segments, which are not available.

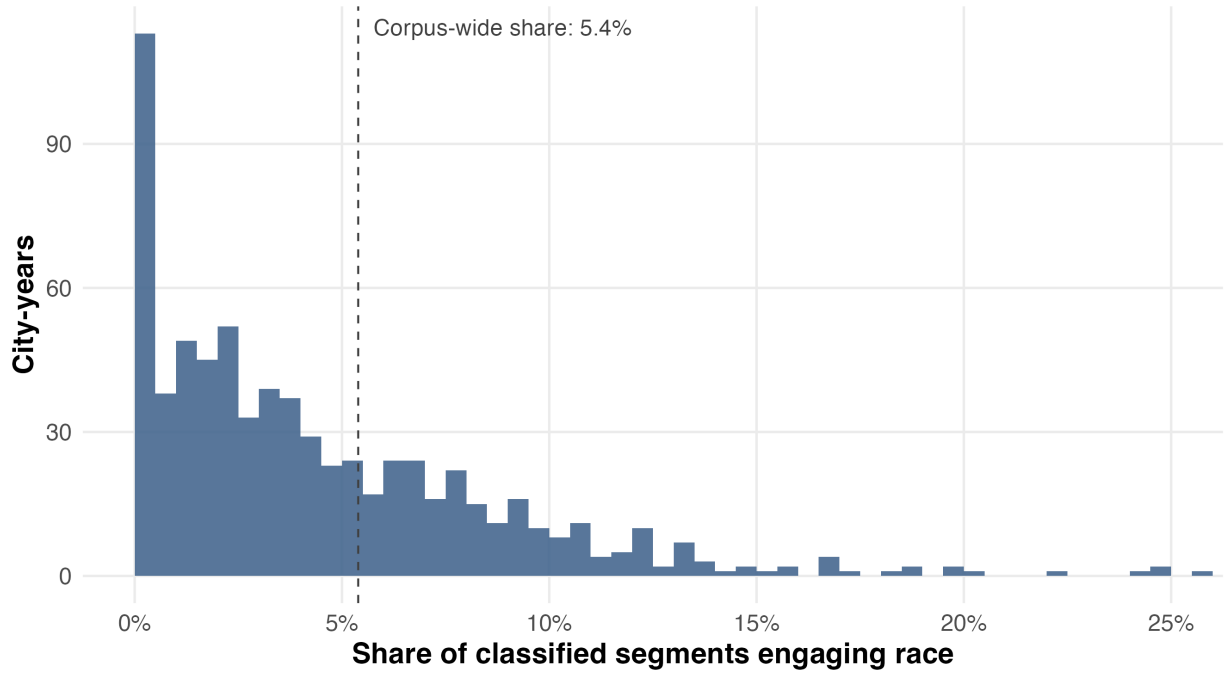
Chapter 7

Descriptive Patterns: Race in Local Meetings

7.1 Race in the Corpus

The share of meeting content that engages race varies substantially across city-years. Figure 7.1 gives the distribution across the 719 classified city-years. The median city-year is 3.4% and the distribution is right-skewed. Thirteen of the 112 cities do not carry a single race-engaging segment. On the other hand, the top tenth of cities account for 40.5% of every race-engaging segment in the corpus. Race is therefore concentrated in a small number of cities.

Figure 7.1: Distribution of Race-Language Across City-Years



City-years by the share of classified segments engaging race. Bins are half a percentage point wide. The dashed line marks the corpus-wide share. The view is clipped at 25 percent, which leaves 11 of 719 city-years outside the frame.

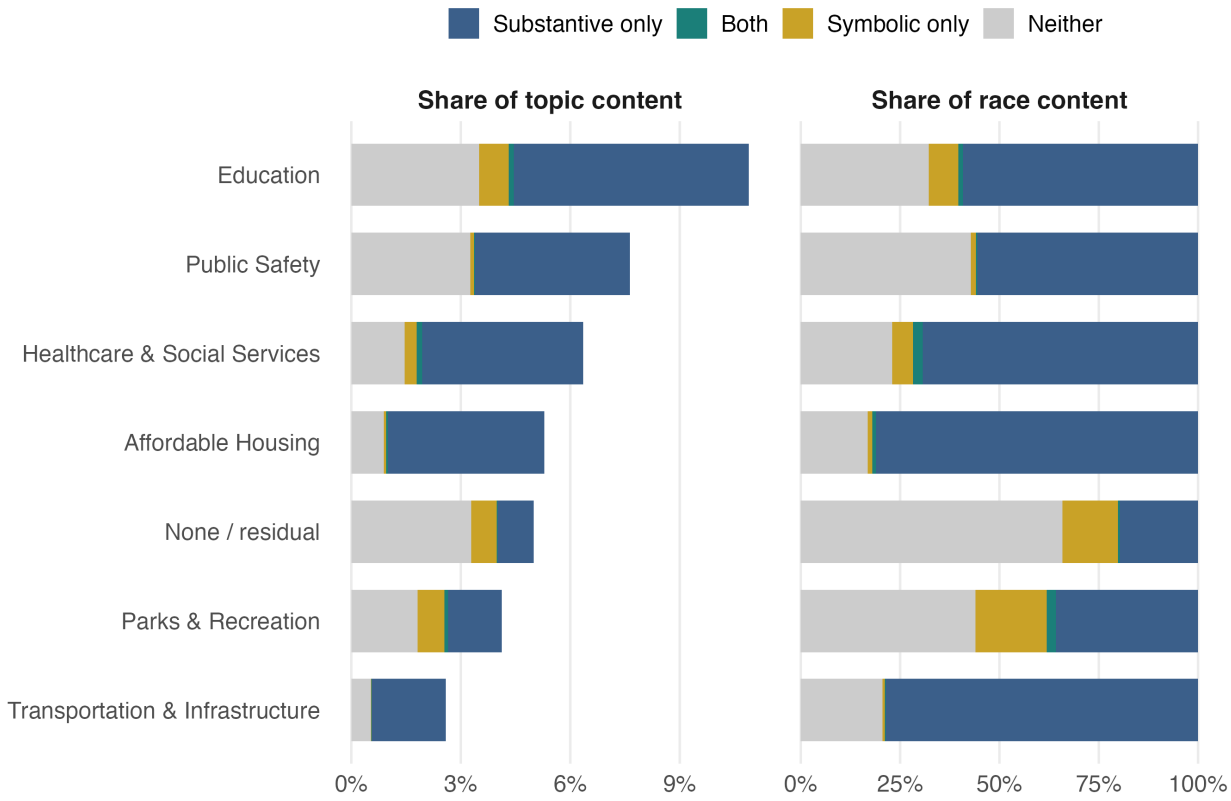
Of the 626 city-years that have race-engaging content, 80.5% carry more substantive than symbolic race-engaging segments. Councils that engage race at all are more likely to use race in a substantive context rather than symbolically.

Distinguishing between substantive and symbolic language describes race-language attached to a policy area far better than it describes the rest. As shown in Table 6.1, a large share of race-engaging segments carries neither a symbolic nor a substantive classification. Among race-engaging segments that also carry one of the six policy categories, 31.0% are classified as neither. Among race-engaging segments in the residual category, 65.9% also are classified as neither. The classifier may be failing on content whose symbolic and substantive status is genuinely ambiguous, or a passing mention of race may be neither symbolic nor substantive in any useful sense. Either way the symbolic and substantive results below should be read as describing the policy-coded half of race-language.

There is a lot of variance in race engagement across policy areas. Figure 7.2 displays the rate for each category in the left panel, as the total height of each bar. Education is the highest at 10.9% of its classified content, followed by public safety at 7.6%, healthcare & social services at 6.4%, affordable housing at 5.3%, the residual at 5.0%, parks & recreation at 4.1%, and transportation & infrastructure at 2.6%. Race enters discussion of schools, libraries, and policing at an increased rate compared to the discussion of roads and transit.

Across all race-engaging content, 43.3% is substantive only against 8.9% symbolic only, and that balance depends on what the discussion is about. The right panel of Figure 7.2 renormalizes each bar to the race-engaging segments within that category. Affordable housing is 81.0% substantive only and 1.2% symbolic only. Transportation & infrastructure is 78.6% and 0.6%. Healthcare & social services is 69.4% and 5.3%. At the other end, parks & recreation is 35.8% substantive only and 18.0% symbolic only, and the residual category is 19.7% and 14.0%. Education sits between them at 59.2% and 7.5%. Segments classified as substantive are more likely to be found in categories that describe spending decisions. Recognition of a group appears alongside proclamations and events.

Figure 7.2: Symbolic and Substantive Language by Policy Topic



Policy topics ordered by the share of their classified content that engages race. The left panel reports each of the four cells as a share of the topic's classified content. The right panel reports the same cells as a share of the topic's race-engaging content. The four cells are mutually exclusive.

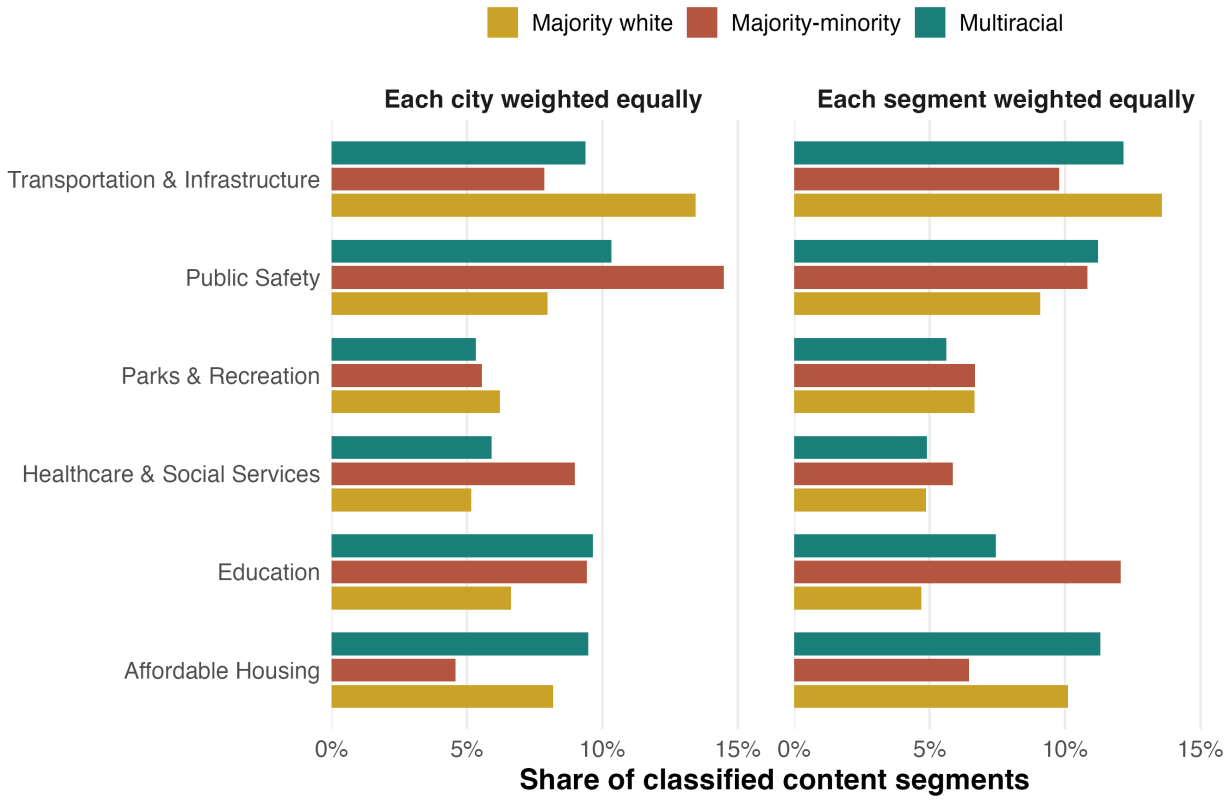
Table 7.1 reports the rates by city type across the classified sample. Multiracial cities engage race in 6.7% of classified content, against 5.1% in majority-minority cities and 4.8% in majority-white cities. Among race-engaging segments, 32.4% are classified as substantive in majority-minority cities against 46.6% in majority-white cities and 45.6% in multiracial cities.

Table 7.1: Race-language by city racial-composition type, pooling segments within type. The race column is a share of classified content. The substantive and symbolic columns are shares of race-engaging segments

Base	City type	Cities	Content segments	Engages race	Substantive, of race	Symbolic, of race
Classified sample	Majority white	50	382,242	4.77%	46.6%	7.3%
Classified sample	Majority-minority	22	112,598	5.06%	32.4%	12.2%
Classified sample	Multiracial	40	202,551	6.74%	45.6%	11.8%
Classified sample	All	112	697,391	5.39%	44.1%	9.7%
Composition base	Majority white	43	97,908	4.89%	48.9%	7.8%
Composition base	Majority-minority	16	21,226	4.61%	37.0%	9.1%
Composition base	Multiracial	33	64,420	7.19%	47.5%	11.9%
Composition base	All	92	183,554	5.67%	47.1%	9.7%

Meeting content varies with city type more clearly than race-language does. Figure 7.3 gives the mix across the six categories under two weightings, one that counts each city once and one that counts each segment once. Weighting cities equally, majority-minority cities devote 14.5% of classified content to public safety against 8.0% in majority-white cities, while majority-white cities devote 13.4% to transportation & infrastructure against 7.9% in majority-minority cities. Education runs 9.4% in majority-minority cities against 6.6% in majority-white ones.

Figure 7.3: Agenda Mix by City Type

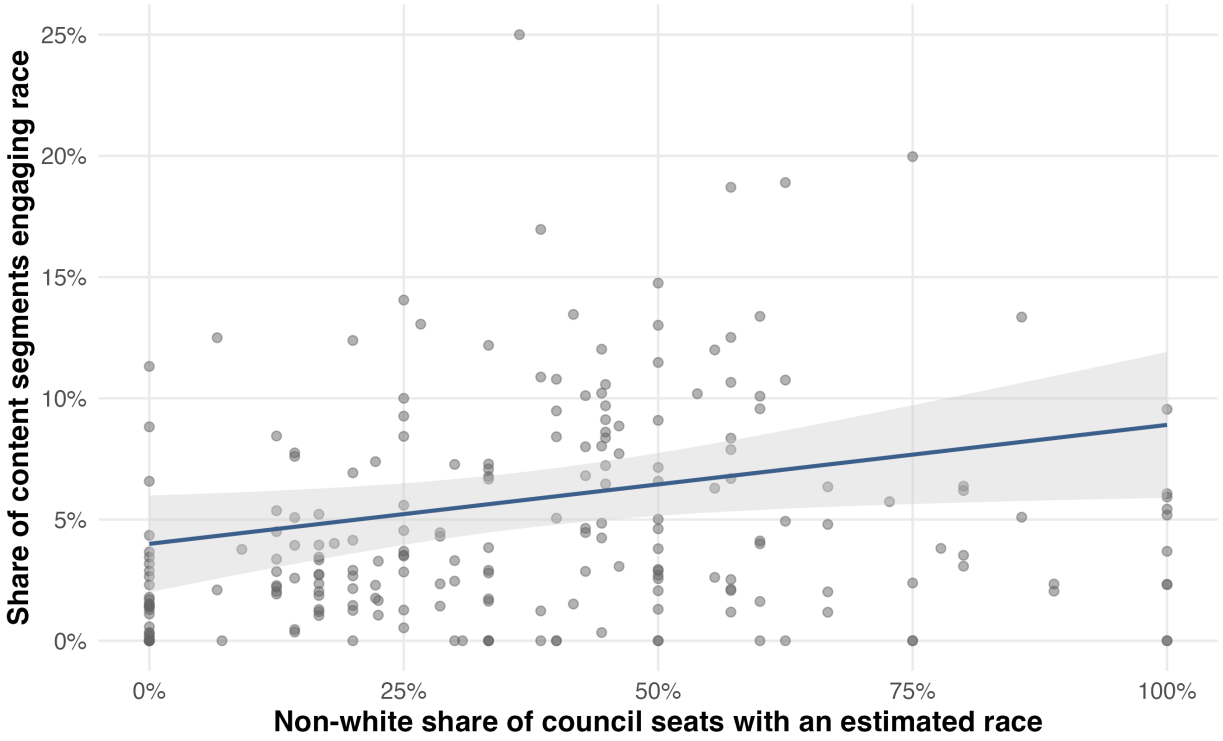


Share of classified content segments in each of the six policy topics, by city type, under two weightings. The residual category is suppressed, so the bars within a panel do not sum to one. Shares are of all classified content, with the residual in the denominator.

7.2 Race and Council Composition

Race-language rises weakly with the non-white share of a council. Figure 7.4 plots the two against each other across the 223 city-years, and Table 7.2 reports a correlation of 0.146. The direction is the one **H1** predicts.

Figure 7.4: Race-Language Against Council Composition



One point per city-year with an observed council. The line is an unweighted bivariate fit with a 95 percent confidence band. The view is clipped at 25 percent, which leaves 5 of 223 city-years outside the frame. This is a cross-sectional association and not an estimate of an effect.

Table 7.2: Associations between meeting content and composition across the city-years with an observed council. The first five rows report correlations. The two OLS rows report the coefficient in percentage points of classified content with its standard error in parentheses. The two composition variables correlate at 0.77 across these city-years. These are cross-sectional associations, not estimates of an effect

Quantity	City-years	Council non-white share	City non-white population share
Engages race	223	0.146	0.070
Substantive, per race segment	199	-0.045	-0.024
Symbolic, per race segment	199	0.050	-0.014
Substantive, per content segment	223	0.102	0.029
Symbolic, per content segment	223	-0.033	-0.032
Engages race, OLS, entered alone	223	4.91 (2.23)	2.99 (2.89)
Engages race, OLS, entered together	223	7.65 (3.50)	-4.58 (4.49)

The two axes of Component 2 do not move together with composition. **H2a** and **H2b** are stated as shares of race-engaging content, and on that denominator Table 7.2 reports a correlation of 0.050 between council non-white share and the symbolic share, and -0.045 for the substantive share. Those two rows rest on the 199 city-years carrying race-engaging content, since a city-year with none has no conditional share to compute. Measured instead as shares of all meeting content, the two correlations run the other way, at -0.033 symbolic and 0.102 substantive. All four correlations fall between 0.03 and 0.11 in magnitude, and changing the denominator reverses the sign on both axes. Read against **H2a** and **H2b** on the denominator the hypotheses use, what little movement there is appears on the symbolic axis rather than the substantive one, which is the configuration the economic-constraint perspective predicts if a constraint operates on delivery and leaves recognition free. Correlations of this size do not establish that configuration on their own.

Two of the three pre-registered directional predictions concord and one runs the wrong way. Table 7.3 places the survey gap, the predicted direction, and the observed correlation with council composition in the same row for each category. Transportation & infrastructure carries a negative survey gap and the strongest negative correlation in the table at -0.172, as **H3c** predicts. Affordable housing carries the largest positive survey gap and a positive correlation of 0.096, as **H3a** predicts, though the correlation is among the weakest. Public safety carries the largest negative survey gap and a positive correlation of 0.094, against the negative direction **H3b** predicts. The word-weighted column runs alongside the segment-weighted one throughout and does not change any sign, so the pattern does not depend on how meetings are weighted within a city-year.

Table 7.3: Policy topic attention against composition. Every row rests on the same 223 city-years with an observed council. The survey gap is the non-white minus white mean allocation in dollars, survey-weighted. Predicted is the direction H3a to H3c commit to and is blank where no prediction was registered. The two council columns compute the topic share from segment counts and from word counts. These are cross-sectional associations, not estimates of an effect

Category	Survey gap	Predicted	Council (segments)	Council (words)	City population
Affordable Housing	+4.91	+	0.096	0.098	0.015
Healthcare & Social Services	+2.90		-0.013	-0.012	0.035
Education	+0.14		0.055	0.059	0.246
Parks & Recreation	-0.93		-0.153	-0.150	-0.168
Transportation & Infrastructure	-2.58	-	-0.172	-0.176	-0.238
Public Safety	-4.44	-	0.094	0.085	0.084

The two composition variables cannot be separated in a cross-section at this sample size. Council non-white share and city non-white population share correlate at 0.77 across these 223 city-years. Entered alone, council composition carries a coefficient of 4.91 percentage points with a standard error of 2.23, and city composition carries 2.99 with a standard error of 2.89. Entered together, as the last row of Table 7.2 reports, the council coefficient rises to 7.65 and the city coefficient turns negative at -4.58, with standard errors of 3.50 and 4.49. Signs flip and precision collapses, which is what collinearity of this degree produces. Councils in this sample largely resemble their cities, and a comparison across cities cannot tell whether meeting content follows the council or the population that elected it. This is the difficulty Swain (1993) identifies in a different setting, where the constituency that produces an officeholder confounds any apparent effect of the officeholder's race.

Chapter 8

Causal Estimates

8.1 Two-Way Fixed Effects Design

The descriptive section left a question a comparison across cities cannot answer. Council and city composition are too closely related across these city-years for a cross-sectional pattern to tell whether meeting content follows the council or the population that elected it. A design that holds the city fixed and lets the council vary can separate them, and a two-way fixed effects design does that by comparing a city to itself across years rather than comparing cities to one another. The TWFE design therefore addresses whether a council's meetings change when its composition shifts. This design also removes the problem that comes from the cross-sectional comparison, with city fixed effects absorbing everything about a place that holds still across a period. These absorbed city characteristics can include population characteristics, regional attributes, institutions, and a city's history of racial politics. For the TWFE design, I use the following model:

$$Y_{it} = \tau S_{it} + \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{it}$$

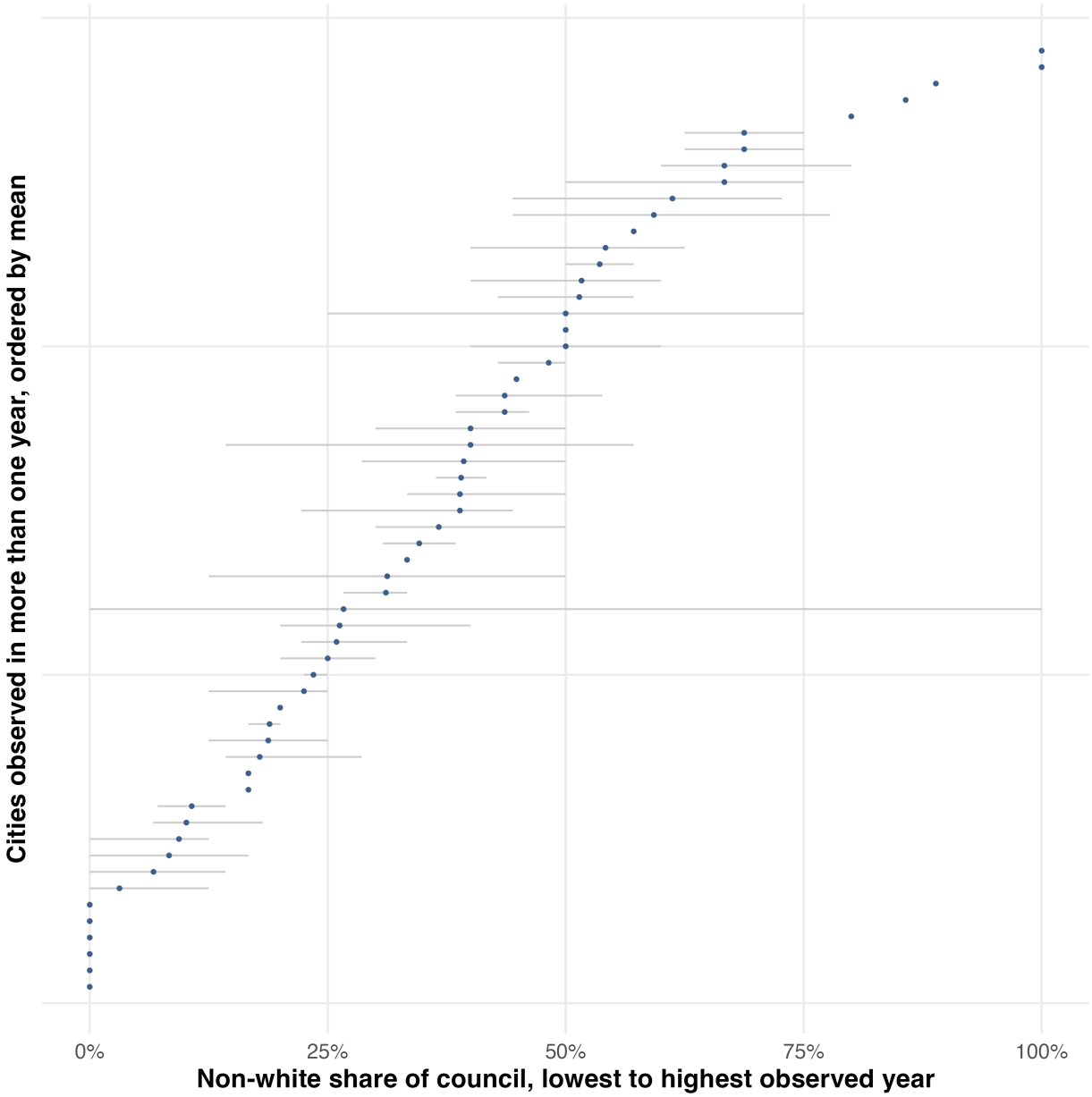
where Y_{it} is the outcome measured across all classified meeting content in city i during year t, and S_{it} is the non-white share of that city's council in that year. The city effect α_i

holds fixed everything about a city that does not change across the period. The year effect γ_t holds fixed anything that moves across every city at once, such as a national event that changes how race is discussed everywhere. Standard errors are clustered on the city, because a city contributes several years and its meetings are not independent draws across them. The quantity of interest is τ, the average within-city association between a council's racial composition and its meeting content.

The treatment is a share, not a binary indicator variable, so τ is expressed per unit of council composition, which is the contrast between an all-white council and an entirely non-white one. No city in this sample makes that comparison, so estimates are reported scaled to a single seat. The median council in the sample holds eight seats, seven of which carry an estimated race, so one seat is roughly fourteen points of the treatment. The estimate is also identified by a minority of the sample. A city observed in only one year contributes nothing to a comparison of a city with itself, and 34 of the 92 cities with an observed council are in that position. A city observed repeatedly whose composition never moves contributes nothing either. Table 5.3 reports how many cities clear each of those two conditions. What is left is 40 cities carrying 137 city-years, and the fixed effects absorb roughly nine tenths of the variation in council composition in the process.

The variation that survives is small but real, and Figure 8.1 plots the range of council composition each city records across the years it is observed. Among the cities that move at all, the median city spans 14.3 percentage points from its lowest observed year to its highest, which is almost exactly one seat on a median council. Between one observation and the next, the median absolute change is 6.7 points, and 40% of the transitions record no change whatsoever. A council that is observed changing is usually observed changing by one seat. The same thinness rules out estimating city-specific time trends, since the median city here is observed in two years and a trend fit to two points would absorb the variation the estimate is meant to use.

Figure 8.1: Within-City Range of Council Composition



One line per city observed in more than one year, running from its lowest to its highest observed non-white council share, with the point marking the city mean. Cities are ordered by that mean. A city whose composition never changes draws a point with no line.

8.2 TWFE Results

Table 8.1 reports the results from the TWFE design. Within cities, a more non-white council is associated with a decrease in the use of race in meetings. Specifically, one additional non-white official is associated with a change of -1.37 percentage points [-5.18, 2.45], an interval that contains zero. The sign of this estimate is the opposite of the council correlation reported in Table 7.2, which is what a within-city comparison can produce when the cross-sectional pattern was carrying differences between cities rather than differences within them. However, the estimated interval is wide enough to be read in any direction.

Table 8.1: Two-way fixed effects estimates of the association between council racial composition and meeting content, with city and year fixed effects and standard errors clustered on the city. Estimates are in percentage points of each outcome's own denominator, scaled to one seat on a council of 7 members with an estimated race. Identifying cities are those observed more than once whose council composition changes.

Outcome	Hypothesis	City-years	Identifying cities	Estimate per seat	95% interval
Engages race	H1	223	40	-1.37 (1.95)	[-5.18, 2.45]
Substantive, per content segment	H2b	223	40	-1.70 (2.00)	[-5.62, 2.22]
Symbolic, per content segment	H2a	223	40	0.05 (0.04)	[-0.02, 0.13]
Substantive, per race segment	H2b	199	36	-4.07 (2.49)	[-8.95, 0.80]
Symbolic, per race segment	H2a	199	36	1.28 (0.95)	[-0.58, 3.14]
Affordable housing	H3a	223	40	-1.64 (1.31)	[-4.21, 0.92]
Public safety	H3b	223	40	0.48 (0.78)	[-1.05, 2.02]
Transportation & infrastructure	H3c	223	40	-0.91 (1.03)	[-2.93, 1.12]
Omnibus composite	Omnibus	223	40	-0.41 (0.64)	[-1.66, 0.85]

No outcome in the table carries an interval that excludes zero, and the directions do not assemble into a consistent account. Of the three predictions in **H3**, only transportation and infrastructure runs in its predicted direction, which also ran in its predicted direction across cities. Affordable housing and public safety both run against their predictions here, and affordable housing ran with its prediction in the cross-section. The two symbolic outcomes carry positive point estimates on both denominators and the two substantive outcomes carry negative ones, which is the configuration the economic-constraint account predicts if a constraint operates on delivery and leaves recognition free. That configuration matches the cross-sectional correlations on the per-race-engaging denominator and reverses them on

the per-content denominator. It is also four point estimates whose intervals all contain zero, so the configuration is a description of this table rather than a finding.

The three topic predictions can also be stated as one quantity. The omnibus signs each of the three topic shares so that the direction **H3** predicts is positive, entering affordable housing as it stands and reversing public safety and transportation & infrastructure, and then averages the three. A council that moved its agenda toward the priorities non-white respondents report would raise it, and a council that moved away from them would lower it. Because the omnibus is a linear combination of the three shares, its coefficient is the signed average of the three topic coefficients above, estimated with a single interval rather than three read alongside one another. The estimate is -0.41 percentage points per seat, with an interval of [-1.66, 0.85]. The agenda moves against the direction **H3** predicts, and the interval contains zero. It spans 1.66 percentage points of movement away from the predicted mix and 0.85 toward it, which leaves the agenda consistent with a modest shift in either direction and rules out large shifts.

8.3 Regression Discontinuity Design

Councils do not change composition at random, and a city whose council becomes more non-white may be changing in other ways at the same time, which city and year effects do not absorb. A design that comes closer to random assignment is available in the elections themselves. For this reason, I compare cities that narrowly elect a non-white candidate against cities that narrowly elect a white candidate. A close elections design allows me to attribute the change in the use of race-language to changes in city council composition.

The running variable is the vote-share margin in the contest closest to being decided differently. Many city council elections elect multiple candidates, so I use the difference between the lowest-placed winning candidate and the highest-placed losing candidate. A contest enters the design when exactly one member of that pair is non-white and the other

is white. The margin is the non-white candidate's vote share minus the white candidate's. I restrict to contests decided within ten points, leaving 362 cross-racial contests across 106 cities. I modeled the construction of the running variable after previous studies of city council elections and racial representation (Beach and D. B. Jones 2017; Beach, D. B. Jones, et al. 2024).

The outcome is the change in a city's meeting content from before the election to after it. I construct my outcome following Benedictis-Kessner, D. Jones, and Warshaw (2025), who measured the difference between the election year and the average of the second and third years following the election, skipping the first year so that newly elected officials have time to act. What this design estimates is a local average treatment effect or the effect of seating a non-white member rather than a white one in the cities where that outcome was close to a coin flip. It does not describe what a council composed differently for some other reason would do, and cities whose cross-racial contests are not close sit outside the comparison entirely.

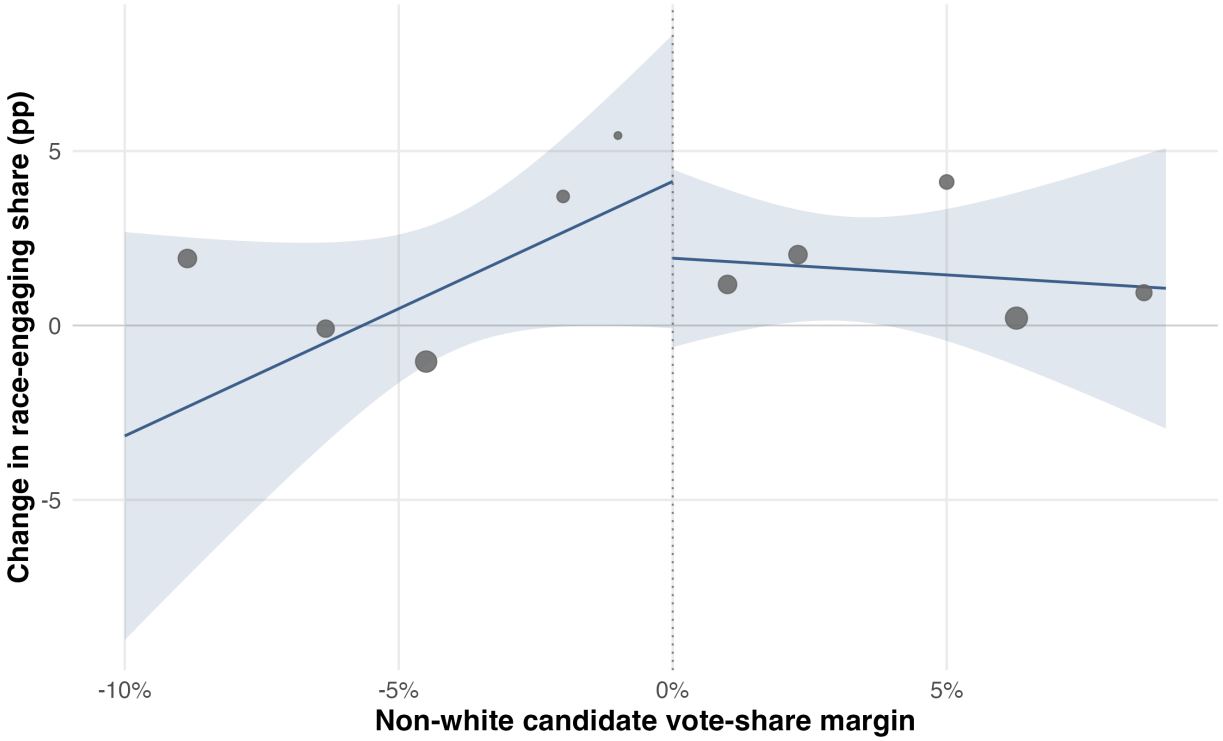
This design is valid if the distribution of potential outcomes is continuous in the running variable at the threshold. Appendix D reports the tests of the RD assumptions, and I find mixed results. A local polynomial manipulation test on the distribution of cross-racial margins rejects continuity of the density of the running variable at the threshold. A rejection would mean that which side of the threshold a contest lands on is not a matter of chance. Non-white candidates would be winning narrowly more often than they lose narrowly because of something about the contests themselves, such as who chooses to run in them or how close outcomes are resolved, and cities just above the threshold would then differ from cities just below in ways that go beyond who took the seat. Other checks do not suggest that the continuity assumption can be rejected. Within the estimation window the contests split 28 below the threshold and 34 above, where the non-white candidate took the seat, which an exact binomial test does not distinguish from an even split. Appendix D gives reasons to doubt that the density result reflects candidates sorting across the threshold, the clearest of

which is that the same test run at a margin where nothing happens rejects more strongly than the test at the real threshold. Balance on city racial composition is too imprecise to confirm the design either, so the appropriate conclusion is that these tests do not establish that continuity fails and do not have the power to establish that it holds.

8.4 RD Results

Narrowly electing a non-white official does not produce a detectable change in how much of a meeting engages race. With an RD that uses a triangular kernel and a local linear fit, Figure 8.2 shows the change in race-language share against the vote margin. The estimate uses 62 of those contests across 37 cities. A contest enters the estimate only when the city carries classified meeting content in both the election year and the post-election window, and most do not. The LATE is estimated as a decrease of 2.2 percentage points [-9.05, 4.65] at the threshold, with bias-corrected estimates reported in Appendix D. The bandwidth is fixed at the 10-point close-election window due to the sample size being too small to calculate a bandwidth.

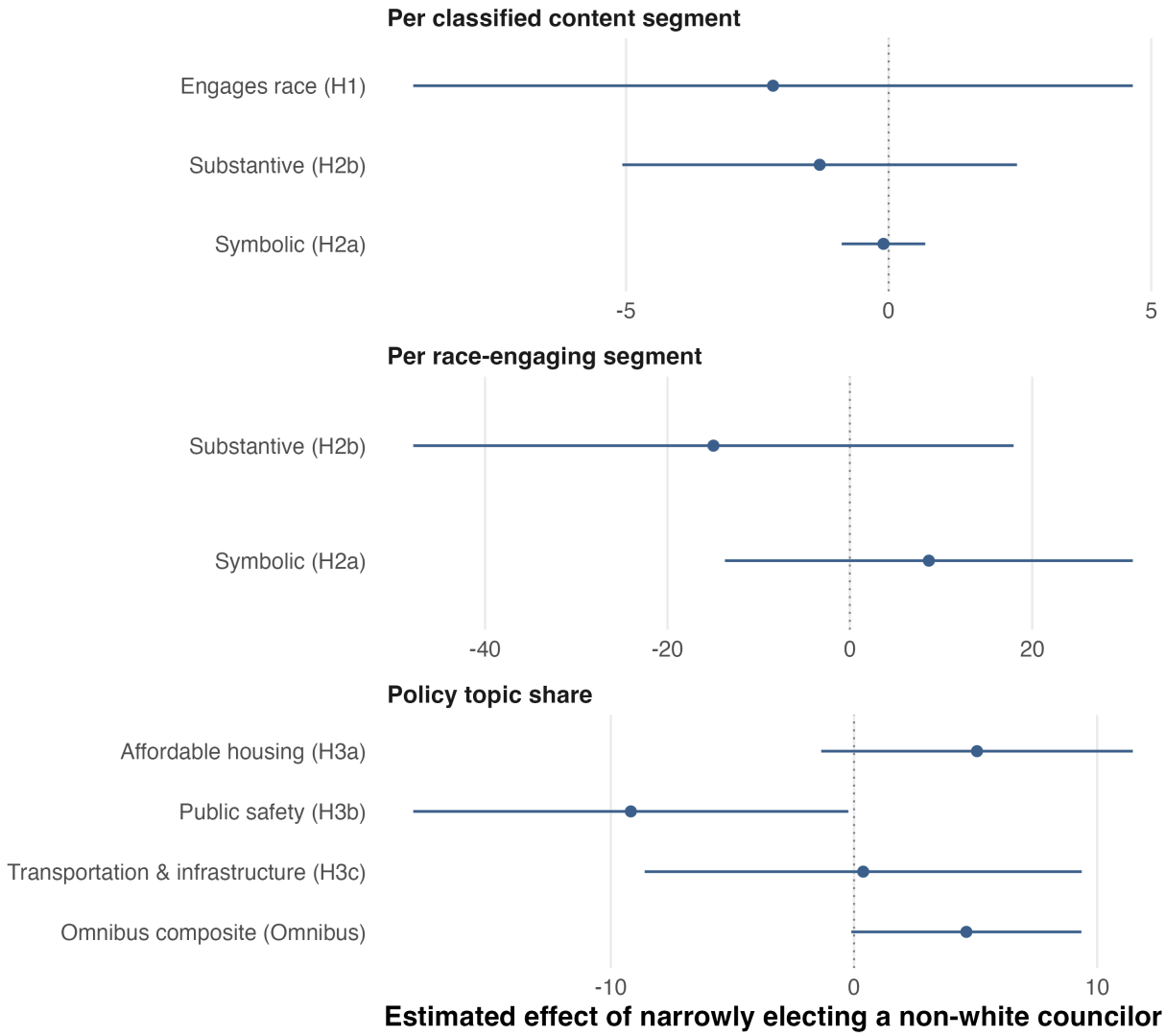
Figure 8.2: RD Results



Binned means of the change in a city's race-engaging share against the non-white candidate's vote-share margin, with point size proportional to the number of contests in a bin. The vertical axis is the change in the share of classified content segments that engage race, in percentage points, measured as the post-election average minus the election-year level. Lines are local linear fits estimated separately on each side, weighted by the triangular kernel at the bandwidth, with 95 percent confidence bands.

Similar results can be found for the remaining hypotheses, and Figure 8.3 reports every estimate together, faceted by denominator. The final row is the omnibus described above, which summarizes **H3** in a single estimate rather than adding a separate prediction. In Figure 8.3, public safety shows an estimate of -9.18 percentage points [-18.10, -0.23], the only interval in the figure that excludes zero, and its bias-corrected interval [-28.3, 1.14] contains zero. Affordable housing shows a positive estimate of 5.06 percentage points [-1.35, 11.5], an interval that contains zero before any bias correction.

Figure 8.3: RD Estimates Across All Outcomes



Conventional point estimates with 95 percent confidence intervals for every pre-registered outcome. The three panels sit on different denominators, per classified content segment, per race-engaging segment, and policy topic share, and each is drawn on its own scale.

The omnibus estimate carries the same construction here, with the pre-post difference in each share signed and averaged rather than the level. Signing and averaging are linear, so the difference this design estimates is the difference in the composite level reported above. The omnibus estimate is 4.62 percentage points with a conventional interval of [-0.11, 9.35] and a bias-corrected interval of [-2.49, 14.2]. The point estimate runs in the predicted direction, where the within-city estimate ran against it. The two designs in this paper use almost

entirely different variation, they do not agree on the sign of this composite, and neither produces an estimate whose interval excludes zero after bias correction. That disagreement is not evidence that the association is absent, because an interval centered near zero rules nothing out when it is this wide.

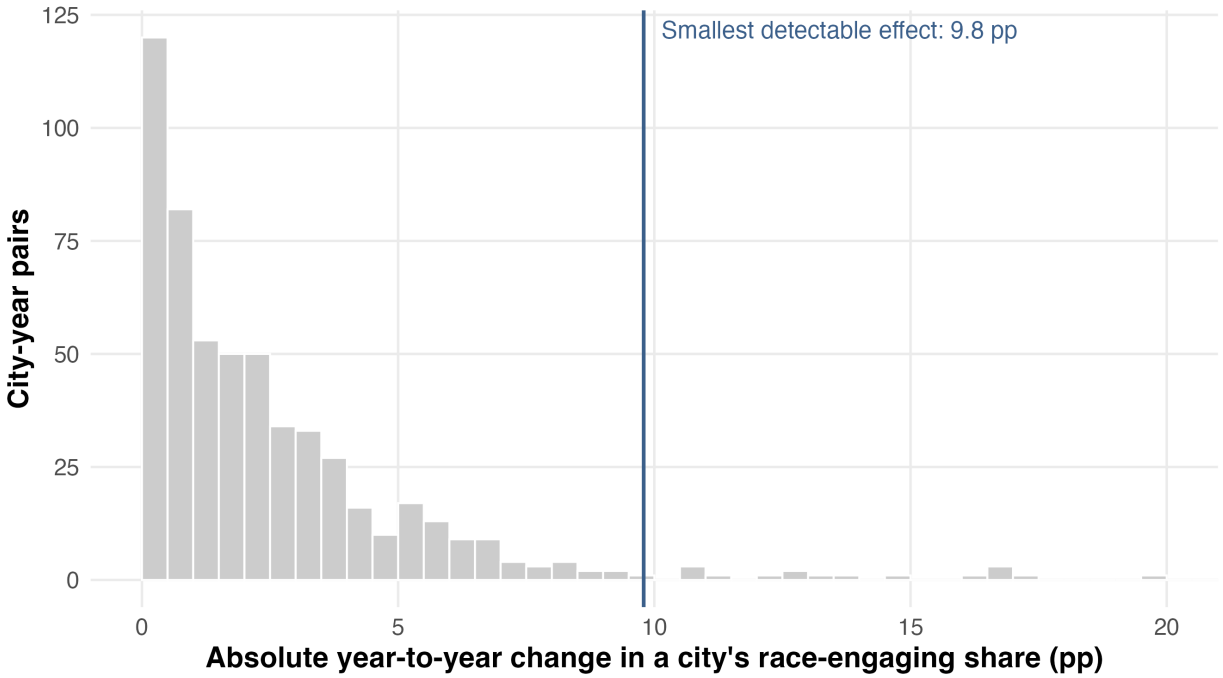
8.5 Power

Neither of the two designs can detect an effect of a size that is plausible. At 80% power, the smallest effect the **H1** estimate could reliably distinguish from 0 is 9.79 percentage points. The mean election-year level of race-language among the same contests is 4.94 percentage points. A detectable effect would have to be double the entire quantity being measured, meaning that the election of a non-white official would cause the use of race-language to triple. Given the current design and estimates, the needed effect size would be implausible and the current tests are uninformative. Appendix D reports the minimal detectable effect for each of the remaining outcomes, and every one of them is larger than the quantity it would move.

The comparison against how city agendas actually move is starker. Across the classified panel, the middle half of city averages spans 5.31 percentage points, while the middle half of a city-year's departure from its own city average spans 2.74 points, so within-city variation is roughly half the size of between-city variation. The concrete version of the same fact is the year-to-year movement. Across 563 adjacent-year observations in 98 cities, the median absolute change in a city's race-engaging share from one year to the next is 1.75 percentage points, and the ninetieth percentile is 6.09 points. Figure 8.4 plots that distribution against the minimum detectable effect. The detection threshold sits beyond the ninetieth percentile of observed annual movement, and 95.7% of the year-to-year changes cities actually record are smaller than the smallest effect this design could find. An effect of a size that cities routinely display would pass through this test undetected. The two-way fixed effects design

above draws on that same within-city movement and faces the same constraint.

Figure 8.4: Detection Threshold Against Observed Year-to-Year Movement



City-year pairs by the absolute change in a city's race-engaging share from one year to the next. Bins are half a percentage point wide. The vertical line marks the smallest effect the **H1** estimate could detect at eighty percent power. The view is clipped at 20 percentage points, which leaves 8 of 563 pairs outside the frame.

What is ruled out is an effect large enough for this design to see, which is an effect that would roughly double or triple the quantity it acts on. What is not ruled out are the effects of the size the descriptive analyses' correlations imply, and the effects of the size cities display from one year to the next. An imprecise estimate centered near zero is not evidence that the effect is zero, and nothing in this section should be read as showing that council composition does not move meeting content. The estimates run in no consistent direction across the nine outcomes. The question of whether council composition causes meeting content to change remains open.

Chapter 9

Discussion

Race is a recurring but concentrated feature of city council meetings. Across the whole sample, 5.4% of content explicitly engages race. When race is engaged, it is more often tied to a policy decision than to recognition, though a substantial share of race-engaging content does neither and simply names a group in passing. Where race meets the areas cities actually budget for, housing and transportation above all, it arrives almost entirely through policy rather than through recognition. Symbolic language has not disappeared from these meetings, but it lives outside the budget categories, in proclamations and observances.

Examining city council transcripts offers insights on descriptive representation by showing where its effects would have to appear and how large they would have to be. Explicit mentions of race are uncommon, uneven across cities, and mainly attached to policy (Minta 2009). A council usually engages race while it is deciding something, which shows that agendas are a good place to look for the effects of city council composition.

City council non-white share and population have a strong correlation with each other. The correlation between these two variables makes it very difficult to assess the hypotheses but there are some patterns to note. **H1** runs in its predicted direction, as well as **H2a** and **H2b**, but the correlations I found in this project cannot directly be attributed to the composition of the city council itself.

Regarding the six policy categories, I have found mixed and inconclusive results. Transportation and infrastructure carries a negative survey gap and the strongest negative correlation in the set as predicted by **H3c**. Affordable housing also runs in its predicted direction, and of the two categories that do, it is the weaker. That is reasonable considering that a group can prioritize housing in the abstract but still be divided on specific developments (Marble and Nall 2021). Public safety also has a negative survey gap and a very small positive correlation with council composition, which goes against what **H3b** predicts.

The causal designs rule out effects large enough for these samples to detect. The regression discontinuity rests on 62 contests and the two-way fixed effects design on 137 identifying city-years, and neither is powered to find an effect of the size cities record from one year to the next. Neither licenses reading any correlation as an effect, and the wide intervals are not evidence that composition does nothing. Estimates are null throughout, and a null this imprecise does not favor the economic-constraint account any more than it favors the alternative.

This paper does observe what a council attends to, and when race is used, whether it is used symbolically or substantively. However, the transcripts do not show who is speaking, whether participants exchange reasons, or whether discussion changes what is decided. The reason-giving exchange at the center of theories of deliberative democracy is not found in what these transcripts can show (Gutmann and Thompson 2004). Despite this, insight is still provided on the content of city council meetings and on how race is utilized by city councils across the United States.

Chapter 10

Conclusion

City governments provide a unique setting where the effects of descriptive representation can be tested. City characteristics could be confounding the effects that a council's characteristics could have on representation. On top of that, because cities compete for land, labor, and capital, they are constrained by their economic positions rather than by the background of their officials. The two arguments predict the same null for different reasons. One is a claim about confounding and one is a claim about what a city can deliver. Race organizes local politics all the same, deciding who wins local office and shaping how a city distributes local goods. What a council attends to is where the main disagreement can be examined, because elections determine who sits on a council and not whose concerns it takes up before deciding anything. Both accounts are built from what a city produces, and a constraint operating on money does not reach the step where problems are identified. Work on local meetings has demonstrated who shows up and who is elected, but what is *said* is a measure that needs to be examined more closely.

Race is a small and concentrated share of what city councils discuss, absent entirely in some cities and recurring in others, and where it appears it is more often attached to something a council could decide than to recognition of a group. Race-language rises with the non-white share of a council, and attention to policy areas also shifts with council

composition. None of these findings can be credited to the council itself. Council composition and city composition are too closely related to be told apart, which is the confounding Swain identifies, arriving here as city characteristics that shape both who sits on a council and what the council does. The designs built to separate them are not powered to detect an effect of a size that cities actually display, so what this paper establishes about the council itself is a boundary rather than an estimate.

Three contributions do not depend on the causal estimate. First, public opinion data was collected on local policy preferences and shows that there are racialized preferences. This survey work establishes a measurement that work on local politics has generally had to assume, since preferences over the goods cities deliver are normally inferred from opinion on national policy. Second, a large language model records whether a council engages race, and whether it engages race symbolically or substantively, across thousands of meetings in a form that supports comparison between cities. Third, because that outcome is measured directly rather than inferred from what a city later funds, the smallest effect either design could detect can be set against how much cities actually move from one year to the next. That comparison is what turns a null into a specification for the study that follows it.

An inconclusive causal estimate leaves the case for looking at the agenda where it was. That case rests on what a constraint operating through money can reach, and naming a problem, hearing from the residents it affects, and directing staff to study it all sit outside its reach. Both designs are built against the confounding rather than against the constraint. A regression discontinuity design on close cross-racial elections and a two-way fixed effects design on year-to-year change within cities each break the link between a council and the city that produced it, which is the objection Swain raises. Neither speaks to the constraint, because a limit on what a city can deliver is not a rival explanation for what a council discusses, and it is the choice of outcome rather than the design that answers it. What the causal designs do establish is what a future design would need, which is either substantially more classified city-years or an identification strategy that is robust to the nuances found

in these data. Nothing in the classification is specific to race or to city councils, and the constraint on extending it is the number of meetings available rather than the method.

Together, these results develop the accounts they were built to test rather than deciding between them. The economic-constraint perspective describes what a city can afford to deliver rather than what a council will discuss. The corpus shows group content on the agenda, engaged substantively more often than symbolically, which locates the constraint at delivery rather than at attention. Whether those engagements change what a city does is a separate question that future work can address. Previous work predicting that composition shapes discussion rests on experiments and on small numbers of meetings, and this paper supplies the scale that work has lacked, since an effect large enough to detect in a causal design would have to exceed what cities display from one year to the next. The difficulty of separating a council from the city that elected it turns out to be structural in local politics rather than incidental to it, since a council that mirrors its city is the ordinary case, and any study of local descriptive representation has to be able to address that relationship.

Local government touches residents most directly and receives the least attention. Local elections are frequently uncontested and local coverage has thinned, so accountability there is unlikely to rest mainly on elections. Whatever accountability local government has is worked out between elections, in the meetings where a council settles what counts as a problem in the first place. That shifts the standard by which a council should be judged. The question is not only whether a council mirrors the city that elected it, but whether the concerns of the people it represents are recognized and taken up before anything is decided. Recognition of that kind is what descriptive representation was meant to deliver, and it is something that can be observed rather than assumed. Studying what councils discuss is not preliminary to studying accountability in local politics, it is a direct way of studying it.

Appendix A

Sample Construction

A.1 The Survey Sample

Table A.1 reports the composition of the allocation analysis sample unweighted and after the survey weights are applied. Homeownership is 2.9 percentage points higher in the weighted sample than in the unweighted sample.

Table A.1: Composition of the allocation analysis sample, unweighted and after applying the survey weights (n = 1,000). Weights range from 0.14 to 4.74 with a median of 0.90. Table 1 reports race in the full eight-category form. Percentages are within block and may not sum to 100 because of rounding

Characteristic	Category	N	Unweighted %	Weighted %
Race	White	681	68.1	66.6
	Black	121	12.1	12.5
	Hispanic	114	11.4	11.4
	Asian	27	2.7	3.3
	Other or multiple	57	5.7	6.3
Gender	Male	489	48.9	48.6
	Female	511	51.1	51.4
Age	18 to 29	211	21.1	20.8
	30 to 44	262	26.2	25.3
	45 to 64	321	32.1	32.7
	65 and over	206	20.6	21.2
Education	High school or less	399	39.9	38.4
	Some college or two-year	266	26.6	27.9
	Four-year degree	213	21.3	21.5
	Postgraduate	122	12.2	12.3
Party identification	Democrat	350	35.0	34.9
	Republican	312	31.2	31.4
	Independent	245	24.5	24.7
	Other or not sure	93	9.3	9.1
Housing	Own	642	64.2	67.1
	Rent	310	31.0	28.8
	Other	48	4.8	4.0
Region	Northeast	176	17.6	17.9
	Midwest	202	20.2	20.4
	South	387	38.7	38.6
	West	235	23.5	23.1

A.2 The Meeting Sample

Table A.2 traces the attrition from the LocalView corpus to the classified sample. The corpus holds 120,071 city council meeting records across 948 cities, which reduce to 119,897 unique meetings once duplicate scrapes are removed. Of those meetings, 32,634 are held in the 123 cities that also appear in the American Local Government Elections Database, and 30,824 are held in the 112 of those cities that produced a classified panel. Those 112 cities contribute 719 city-years to the classified panel, and the corpus holds 29,061 meetings in them. The per-city-year cap draws 8,825 of those meetings, 30.4% of the eligible total, and that draw is the sample every classified quantity in this paper is computed on.

Table A.2: Attrition from the LocalView corpus to the classified sample. Each row counts the meetings surviving every restriction above it

Step	Cities	City-years	Meetings
Meeting records in the corpus	948	5,662	120,071
Unique meetings	948	5,662	119,897
In cities also in the elections database	123	864	32,634
In cities with a classified panel	112	803	30,824
In city-years in the classified panel	112	719	29,061
Drawn under the per-city-year cap	112	719	8,825

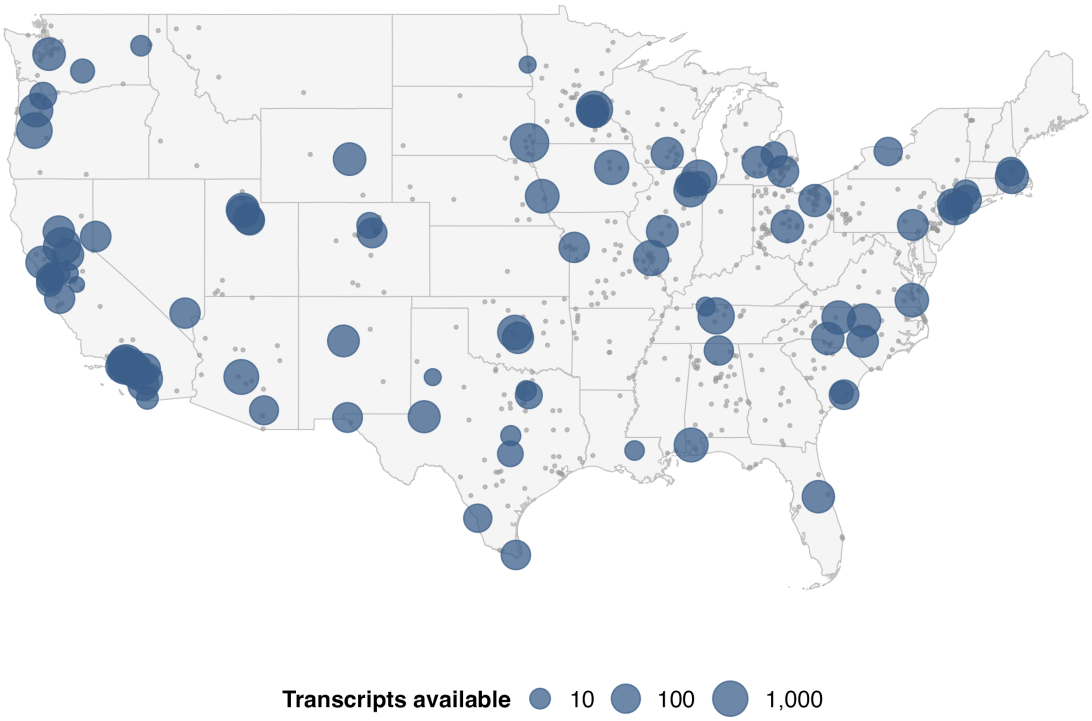
Table A.3 reports coverage for the full corpus and the classified sample in adjacent columns. The dictionary runs on every usable meeting and the classification runs only on the capped draw, so a single coverage figure conflates the two and makes the classified sample appear far larger than it is. The maximum meetings per city-year row is the cap audit, and it reads 20.

Table A.3: Coverage of the full corpus and the classified sample. The dictionary runs on every usable meeting; the classification runs on a random draw capped at 20 meetings per city-year

Quantity	Full corpus	Classified sample
Cities	948	112
City-years	5,662	719
Meetings	119,897	8,825
Median meetings per city-year	15	15
90th percentile meetings per city-year	42	20
Maximum meetings per city-year	785	20
City-years above the cap	2,154	0
Classified content segments		697,391

Figure A.1 plots the classified cities against the corpus they were drawn from. The 112 classified cities sit in 33 states, California holds 37 cities, and four states hold half of the cities in the sample. What the figure shows is where transcript availability and election data availability overlap, and that overlap is concentrated rather than spread evenly.

Figure A.1: The LocalView Corpus and the Classified Sample



Grey points are corpus cities that do not enter the classified sample. Colored points are the 112 classified cities, sized by the number of transcripts available in the city. Alaska, Hawaii, and the territories sit outside the frame.

Appendix B

Classification

Each classified segment received ten judgments from a single model call. The model returned the segment's policy area from the six survey categories plus a residual, the identity category the segment most centrally engages, whether that identity content is explicit, whether it is implicit, the phrase triggering an implicit call, the speaker's posture toward the group, whether the segment is symbolic, whether it is substantive, a confidence level, and a short rationale. Classification used `gpt-5.4-mini` in batches of ten segments. The output is cached with a hash of the prompt, so any changes to the prompt or the model would start an entirely fresh classification process.

B.1 Segmentation Parameters

Segmentation runs on transcript text before anything is classified. Each transcript is divided into consecutive blocks of 40 words, and each block is embedded with `text-embedding-3-small`. Cosine similarity between adjacent blocks produces a sequence in which topic shifts appear as valleys. The depth of a gap is how far similarity at that gap falls below the nearest higher point on each side, summed across the two sides. Candidate boundaries are the local minima of that sequence, and a candidate becomes a boundary when its depth exceeds the mean depth among candidates less half a standard deviation. No segment is cut shorter than 60

words, and a run growing past 250 words is cut whether or not a valley is available there.

Table B.1 reports where boundaries actually fall. A boundary is semantic when it lands at a valley meeting the depth criterion and forced when the maximum-length rule intervenes first. The balance between the two is what shows whether the depth criterion is doing the work or the length cap is. Shares are computed over placed boundaries rather than over all segments, since the start of a meeting is not a cut.

Table B.1: How segment boundaries were placed. Shares exclude meeting starts, which are not cuts

Boundary	Segments	Share of segments	Share of cuts
Semantic (similarity valley)	557,873	80.0%	81.0%
Forced (max length)	131,046	18.8%	19.0%
Meeting start (not a cut)	8,825	1.3%	

A segment is set aside as procedural when it runs shorter than 50 words and matches at least one procedural pattern. Both conditions are required, so a long stretch of roll call and motion language stays in the classified set rather than being discarded on a pattern match. The gate is conservative, because a wrongly excluded segment is invisible to the model, while a wrongly included segment is only labeled as residual.

B.2 Classifying Race

The classifier labels identity content of any kind and a gate then decides what counts as racial. Table B.2 lists the eleven categories the model can return and marks which are in frame. Labeling out-of-frame content rather than discarding it is what makes the size of the gate visible.

Table B.2: Identity categories returned by the classifier, and which are in frame. The construct is white against non-white racial and ethnic identity. Out-of-frame content is labeled and then gated out rather than left unrecorded.

Category	In frame	What it covers
`black`	Yes	Black or African American
`hispanic_latino`	Yes	Hispanic or Latino
`asian_pacific_islander`	Yes	Asian or Pacific Islander
`native_american`	Yes	Native American, American Indian, Indigenous, tribal
`race_general`	Yes	Racism, racial equity, profiling, redlining, segregation, or civil rights history, with no group named
`immigration`	Conditional	Immigrant, refugee, or undocumented framing with no group named. In frame only when the stance is not hostile
`gender_sexuality`	No	Gender, sex, sexual orientation, LGBTQ status
`religion`	No	Religious identity
`other_ethnicity`	No	White-ethnic or Middle Eastern national origin
`other_identity`	No	Disability, age, or veteran status
`none`	No	No identity group or concept engaged

A named group takes precedence over the two fallback categories. A segment about Hispanic immigrants is recorded as Hispanic or Latino rather than as immigration, and a segment about Vietnamese refugees is recorded as Asian or Pacific Islander. The immigration and general-race categories apply only where no group is named. Without this rule the fallbacks absorb group-specific content and every per-group count runs low.

Stance records posture toward the group rather than the tone of the words. Opposing a detention center, condemning deportations, or describing discrimination is supportive of the affected group, because the criticism is aimed at something that harms it. Only hostility toward the group itself is counted, and a speaker recounting or denouncing a racist act is judged on their own position.

The gate runs in three steps. A category is in frame when it is one of the five racial categories, or when it is immigration and the recorded stance is not hostile. A segment is race-relevant when it carries explicit or verified implicit identity content and its category is

in frame. Symbolic and substantive are then recorded only on race-relevant segments, so a segment the gate excludes cannot carry either marker.

A hostile segment about a named in-frame group counts as being race-relevant. Hostility directed at a group is engagement with race, and excluding it would make the measure record only favorable attention. What such a segment fails is the symbolic and substantive tests rather than the gate, since hostility is neither commemoration nor policy. Immigration is the single exception, because immigration language with no group named and a hostile stance is too ambiguous to treat as non-white racial content.

The treatment and the outcome do not cover the same categories. The elections database records Black, Hispanic, and Asian council members and carries no Native American category, while the model includes Native American. The treatment is therefore a proxy for non-white council presence bounded by what is available in the data.

B.3 The Classification Prompt

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You classify short excerpts from U.S. city council meeting transcripts. The
text is from automatic captions and may be messy or unpunctuated.

THE FRAME (read first). This project studies race and ethnicity in the
white / non-white sense. The groups and concepts that are IN FRAME:
  - Black / African American
  - Hispanic / Latino
  - Asian / Pacific Islander
  - Native American / American Indian / Indigenous / tribal
  - race in general with no named group: racism, racial equity, racial
    profiling, redlining, segregation, civil-rights history
  - immigrants / refugees / undocumented residents
Identity content that is OUT OF FRAME and is NOT the project's racial construct:
religion (Jewish, Muslim, Catholic), gender or sex, sexual orientation or LGBTQ
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status, disability, age, veteran status, and white-ethnic or Middle Eastern national origin (Armenian, Irish, Italian, Ukrainian, Lebanese). You still LABEL these when they appear (via race_basis) so they can be counted; they are simply not the racial construct.

For EACH numbered segment return one object with these fields:

- index: the segment's number, as given.

- topic: the single best-fitting policy area, EXACTLY one of: affordable_housing, education, healthcare_social_services, parks_recreation, public_safety, transportation_infrastructure, none.
  Use 'none' for procedural, ceremonial, or off-topic content.

- race_basis: the single identity category the segment most centrally engages, EXACTLY one of: black, hispanic_latino, asian_pacific_islander, native_american, race_general, immigration, gender_sexuality, religion, other_ethnicity, other_identity, none.
  PRECEDENCE (most important): if the segment names or unmistakably points to a specific in-frame group (Black, Hispanic/Latino, Asian/Pacific Islander, Native American), use THAT GROUP as race_basis, even when the segment is also about immigration, refugees, equity, or civil rights. So 'Hispanic immigrants' is hispanic_latino, not immigration; 'Vietnamese refugees' is asian_pacific_islander, not immigration. 'immigration' and 'race_general' are FALLBACKS ONLY for content with no named in-frame group: use 'immigration' for immigrant / refugee / undocumented framing with no named group, and 'race_general' for racism / racial equity / civil-rights language with no named group. Use 'gender_sexuality', 'religion', 'other_ethnicity' (white-ethnic or Middle Eastern origin), or 'other_identity' (disability, age, veteran) for out-of-frame identity content. Use 'none' when no identity group or concept is engaged at all.
  MULTIPLE IN-FRAME GROUPS: when several in-frame groups are named together (e.g. African Americans and Latinos), choose the one that is the main subject;

if they are equally central, either is acceptable, since all in-frame groups collapse to the same white/non-white category for the analysis.
NON-IDENTITY WORD SENSES (use 'none', never an identity basis): 'race' meaning a contest, election, or competition (a car race, a political race); 'inclusive' meaning enumeration ('items 1 through 9 inclusive'); 'equitable' or 'equity' meaning financial or ownership fairness; 'diverse' or 'diversity' about businesses, revenue, or crops rather than people. Judge by the sense actually used in the segment, not the bare word.

- race_explicit: true if the segment EXPLICITLY names an identity group or concept (of ANY basis, in or out of frame); false if race_basis is 'none' or the connection is only implicit.

- race_implicit: true ONLY if the LANGUAGE IN THE SEGMENT ITSELF carries an identity framing without naming a group (coded references, named programs with clear salience such as ESL or language access, framing like 'those people' or 'that part of town'). Judge ONLY from the words present. Do NOT infer the composition of any neighborhood, school, person, place, or program. If the relevance would depend on knowing who lives somewhere or who is affected, set this false. Be conservative: when unsure, false.

- implicit_cue: if race_implicit is true, the exact phrase from the segment that triggered it; otherwise an empty string. Quote only words that appear.

- race_stance: the posture toward the GROUP or COMMUNITY itself, EXACTLY one of: supportive, neutral, hostile, none. Judge whether the speaker is FOR or AGAINST the group's
interests and wellbeing, NOT the emotional tone of the segment. A segment can be full of negative words (detention, deportation, discrimination, 'horrible', 'blood money') and still be SUPPORTIVE, when that negativity is aimed at something that HARMS the group.
  * supportive: advocates for, defends, or positively recognizes the group or its interests (funding a community's services, honoring contributions, 'a

land of immigrants'). This INCLUDES criticizing a policy, program, actor, or condition that HARMS the group: opposing an immigrant detention center, condemning deportations or ICE raids, decrying discrimination or a slur against the group, calling a private prison 'blood money'. Criticizing a program that SERVES the group is also still supportive ('the immigrant services office is underfunded').

  * hostile: expresses animus toward the GROUP ITSELF, or advocates AGAINST the group's interests: portraying the group as criminals, burdens, or invaders ('undocumented immigrants drain our services'), opposing the group's presence, a slur used against the group, 'those people are the problem'.
  * neutral: a demographic, procedural, or factual mention with no clear posture for or against the group.
  * none: when race_basis is 'none'.

  DECISION RULE: opposing a detention center, prison, deportation, raid, or enforcement action, or opposing discrimination against the group, is SUPPORTIVE of the affected group. Only animus toward the group, or advocacy against the group, is hostile.

  REPORTED OR CONDEMNED hostility: judge the SPEAKER'S own posture, not the posture of speech they quote, report, or condemn. Someone recounting or denouncing a racist act against the group ('a man told her to go back to Africa and shoved her') is SUPPORTIVE of or neutral toward the group, not hostile. Hostile requires the SPEAKER to voice the animus themselves.

- symbolic: true ONLY if the segment COMMEMORATES, honors, recognizes, or ceremonially affirms an identity group or concept (a Black History Month proclamation, honoring a civil-rights figure, a heritage-month declaration, a land acknowledgment, 'a land of immigrants'). COMMEMORATIVE / RECOGNITIONAL speech only. A grievance, complaint, insult, demographic observation, lawsuit, or general announcement is NOT symbolic. General ceremony NOT about an identity group (invocations, the pledge, honoring veterans as such, memorials for individuals) is NOT symbolic. False if no identity content.

- substantive: true ONLY if the segment ties an identity group or concern to a

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  concrete policy, resource, program, or decision (funding language access for
  immigrant residents, debating policing in racial terms, fair-housing
  enforcement). General policy NOT about an identity group (retiree insurance, a
  sewer line) is NOT substantive. False if no identity content.

  symbolic and substantive are INDEPENDENT: both, one, or neither can be true.
  Both require identity content; if race_basis is 'none', both are false.

- confidence: low, medium, or high.

- rationale: at most 12 words; name the identity content and its basis, or say
  'not identity'.

Worked examples:
  * 'in the name of essec johnson and leon broussard ... we are adjourned'
    -> race_basis none; race_explicit false; race_stance none; symbolic false;
       substantive false.
  * 'thank you for your service, everyone who has worn a uniform'
    -> race_basis other_identity; race_explicit true; race_stance supportive;
       symbolic false; substantive false.
  * 'overview of other post-employment retiree health benefits'
    -> race_basis none; all identity fields false.
  * 'whereas February is Black History Month, the council recognizes the
    contributions of African American residents' -> race_basis black;
    race_explicit true; race_stance supportive; symbolic true; substantive false.
  * 'approve $80,000 to expand language-access services so Spanish-speaking and
    Hmong residents can file permits' -> race_basis hispanic_latino OR
    asian_pacific_islander (either in-frame group is fine); race_explicit true;
    race_stance supportive; symbolic false; substantive true.
  * 'proclaiming Indigenous Peoples Day, the council directs staff to consult the
    tribal council on the development agreement' -> race_basis native_american;
    race_explicit true; race_stance supportive; symbolic true; substantive true.
  * a hostile public comment attacking a Black official -> race_basis black;
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race_explicit true; race_stance hostile; symbolic false; substantive false.

* 'we honor the victims of the Armenian Genocide this remembrance day'
  -> race_basis other_ethnicity; race_explicit true; race_stance supportive;
     symbolic true; substantive false.
* 'we must stop these illegal immigrants from draining our services'
  -> race_basis immigration; race_explicit true; race_stance hostile;
     symbolic false; substantive false.
* 'America has always been a land of immigrants and we celebrate that heritage'
  -> race_basis immigration; race_explicit true; race_stance supportive;
     symbolic true; substantive false.
* 'these detention centers are horrible; building an immigrant detention center
  here is wrong and it will tear the fabric of our community' -> race_basis
  immigration; race_explicit true; race_stance SUPPORTIVE (opposing a policy
  that harms immigrants, NOT hostility toward immigrants); symbolic false;
  substantive true.
* 'five undocumented residents were deported and a child has not seen her
  mother since' -> race_basis immigration; race_explicit true; race_stance
  supportive (sympathetic to those harmed by deportation); symbolic false;
  substantive false.
* 'a man told her to go back to Africa and then shoved her out of the store'
  -> race_basis black; race_explicit true; race_stance supportive (the speaker
  is recounting racist harassment, not voicing it); symbolic false;
  substantive false.
* 'this June we recognize Pride and our LGBTQ community' -> race_basis
  gender_sexuality; race_explicit true; race_stance supportive; symbolic true;
  substantive false.
* 'our Hispanic brothers and sisters, many undocumented, have every right to be
  anxious' -> race_basis hispanic_latino (a group is NAMED, so NOT immigration);
  race_explicit true; race_stance supportive; symbolic false; substantive false.
* 'we mark the fall of Saigon; millions of Vietnamese refugees lost our country'
  -> race_basis asian_pacific_islander (Vietnamese NAMED, so NOT immigration);
  race_explicit true; race_stance supportive; symbolic true; substantive false.
* 'sanctuary policy protects our immigrant residents' (no group named)

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    -> race_basis immigration; race_explicit true; race_stance supportive.
  * 'we have a big race fan rally downtown this weekend' -> race_basis none
    ('race' = a competition, not identity); all identity fields false.
  * 'approve items seven through nine inclusive' -> race_basis none
    ('inclusive' = enumeration); all identity fields false.

Return a JSON object: {"results": [ one object per segment, in input order ]}.
```

Appendix C

The Dictionary

The dictionary is borrowed rather than built from scratch. Its terms come from the dictionaries Dietrich and Hayes (2023) and Vishwanath (2025) use to measure attention to race in congressional speech, which is the same literature Component 1 extends from Congress to city councils. The list is organized into three groups that follow the structure of Component 1. Group mentions are direct references to racial and ethnic groups and their members, including variants of Black, African American, Hispanic, Latino, Asian American, Native American, Pacific Islander, people of color, and racial minority. Equity language covers terms such as racism, discrimination, marginalized, diversity, and gentrification. Civil-rights references cover terms for civil-rights history and its symbols, such as civil rights, fair housing, Martin Luther King, Rosa Parks, Jim Crow, and Juneteenth.

Three matching rules govern how the list is applied. Matching is case-insensitive and uses word boundaries, so race does not match inside embrace and asian does not match inside caucasian. Multi-word phrases are matched before single words so that a phrase is not counted twice. Bare nationality terms such as Chinese and Mexican are excluded because they frequently refer to countries and governments rather than to people, so only compound forms such as Chinese American and Mexican American are retained. The list runs on every usable meeting in the corpus rather than on the classified sample, and it returns a count of

hits per thousand words rather than a judgment about a stretch of discussion.

The dictionary and the classifier are independent instruments applied to the same segments, so their disagreements are informative about both. Table C.1 crosses the model's in-frame explicit race calls against word-boundary dictionary hits, restricted to the classified segments where both instruments are available. Neither instrument is a gold standard, so the two disagreement cells are not errors in a known direction. Segments the model calls explicit and the dictionary misses reflect language no fixed list covers. Segments the dictionary hits and the model does not are largely word-sense cases, such as race as a contest or equity as an ownership stake, which is the disambiguation a fixed list cannot perform.

Table C.1: The model's in-frame explicit race calls against word-boundary dictionary hits, over the classified segments where both instruments are available

Cell	Segments	Share of classified content
Neither	639,539	91.70%
Both instruments	22,698	3.25%
Dictionary only	21,176	3.04%
Model only	13,978	2.00%

The two instruments measure different things, which is why the analyses are not run both ways. The dictionary records whether a term appears. The classifier records whether a stretch of discussion engages race, which is the construct the hypotheses are stated in. The dictionary also carries no information about how race is engaged or about what a discussion is about, so Components 2 and 3 have no dictionary counterpart at all. Running the full analysis on both would produce a second set of Component 1 results on a different sample, at a different unit, and on a different denominator, and no results for the other two components. The dictionary is used as a corpus-wide descriptive and as a check on the classifier rather than as a parallel measure.

This comparison does not establish that the classifier is correct. It sets one instrument against another rather than against human coding, and neither large-scale hand validation nor design-based correction for predicted variables used as outcomes is undertaken here.

Appendix D

Design Diagnostics

D.1 The Running Variable

Table D.1 reports the tests behind the continuity discussion in the main text.

Table D.1: Continuity checks at the threshold. The manipulation tests are local polynomial density tests run on the full distribution of close cross-racial margins before the close-election restriction, because a test run on the restricted frame has a boundary at the bandwidth. The placebo test is run at a margin where no discontinuity should exist. The binomial test compares the split of contests either side of the threshold within the estimation window

Quantity	Value
Manipulation test at the threshold, p	0.009
Placebo manipulation test at a margin of -0.075, p	0.000
Contests below the threshold	28
Contests at or above the threshold	34
Exact binomial test of an even split, p	0.526
Distinct values of the running variable in the window	30
Contests with a margin of exactly zero, dropped	23

The manipulation test at the threshold returns a p-value of 0.009. The same test run at a margin of -0.075, where no discontinuity should exist, returns a p-value below 0.001. The estimator selects bandwidths of 0.20 to the left and 0.16 to the right, against an estimation window of 0.10, so both tests read a span of contests wider than the design uses. The running variable takes 30 distinct values within the window.

A rejection at the threshold would ordinarily mean that contests do not fall either side of it

by chance, and that non-white candidates win narrowly more often than they lose narrowly for reasons connected to the contests themselves. Three features of this running variable argue against that reading. The placebo rejects more strongly than the real threshold at a margin where nothing happens, which is the signature of an estimator responding to the shape of the distribution rather than to a discontinuity at any particular point. The selected bandwidths are one and a half to two times the estimation window, so the tests are reading a span of contests wider than the design uses. Thirty distinct values across the window make the density coarse, and a density estimator reads coarseness as structure.

Contests split 28 below the threshold and 34 at or above it, which an exact binomial test of an even split returns at 0.526. Twenty-three contests with a margin of exactly zero are dropped. A tie is recorded as a non-white loss in the elections data, and a sharp design would assign it to treatment, because the running variable does not determine treatment at the threshold itself.

D.2 Balance

Table D.2 reports the estimated jump at the threshold in two pre-determined city characteristics, together with a placebo estimate on the election-year outcome measured before the council changes. Units differ by row. None of the three intervals excludes zero, and none is narrow enough to establish balance.

Table D.2: Balance on pre-determined characteristics and a placebo on the pre-treatment outcome. Units differ by row and are named in the first column. The placebo is in percentage points of classified content, the population share is a share, and city size is in log points. No row rejects, and none is precise enough to establish balance

Quantity	Contests	Estimate	Conventional interval	Bias-corrected	R
Placebo: election-year race share (pp)	74	-4.362	[-12.844, 4.121]	-2.794	[-
City non-white population (share)	62	0.201	[-0.031, 0.433]	0.252	[-
City population (log points)	62	-0.196	[-1.323, 0.932]	-0.362	[-

D.3 Minimum Detectable Effects

Table D.3 reports the smallest effect each estimate could detect. The detectable effect is $(z_{0.975} + z_{0.80})$ times the conventional standard error, which is the smallest true effect a two-sided five percent test would reject the null for eighty percent of the time. It is computed from the standard error the fit returned rather than from a simulation, so it describes this sample rather than a hypothetical one. It is reported in percentage points of the denominator named in the second column, which differs by row.

Table D.3: The smallest effect each estimate could detect, in percentage points of the denominator named. The ratio is the detectable effect divided by the mean election-year level of the same quantity

Outcome	Denominator	Contests	Detectable effect	Election-year level	Ratio
Engages race (H1)	Per classified content segment	62	9.79	4.94	1.98
Symbolic (H2a)	Per classified content segment	62	1.14	0.34	3.30
Substantive (H2b)	Per classified content segment	62	5.37	2.37	2.26
Symbolic (H2a)	Per race-engaging segment	56	31.97	7.07	4.52
Substantive (H2b)	Per race-engaging segment	56	47.06	42.22	1.11
Affordable housing (H3a)	Policy topic share	62	9.16	8.18	1.12
Public safety (H3b)	Policy topic share	62	12.79	9.58	1.34
Transportation & infrastructure (H3c)	Policy topic share	62	12.85	10.11	1.27
Omnibus composite (Omnibus)	Policy topic share	62	6.76		

The final column divides the detectable effect by the mean election-year level of the same quantity. A ratio above one means the design can only detect effects larger than the entire quantity they would move. Every outcome carrying a baseline level has a ratio above one. The smallest is 1.11, on the substantive share of race-engaging content, and the largest is 4.52, on the symbolic share of the same denominator. **H1** sits at 1.98. The omnibus composite has no baseline level, so no ratio is computed for it.

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